
RSW
RETRO SPACE WARS
A MULTIPLAYER STRATEGY GAME OF
INTERSTELLAR CONQUEST
http://rswgame.com

RSW Version 1.0.8.8

Contents

RSW Help

Welcome to the RSW game rules and help. These help pages can be used as a quick reference to answer a particular question, or they may be read straight through from beginning to end.

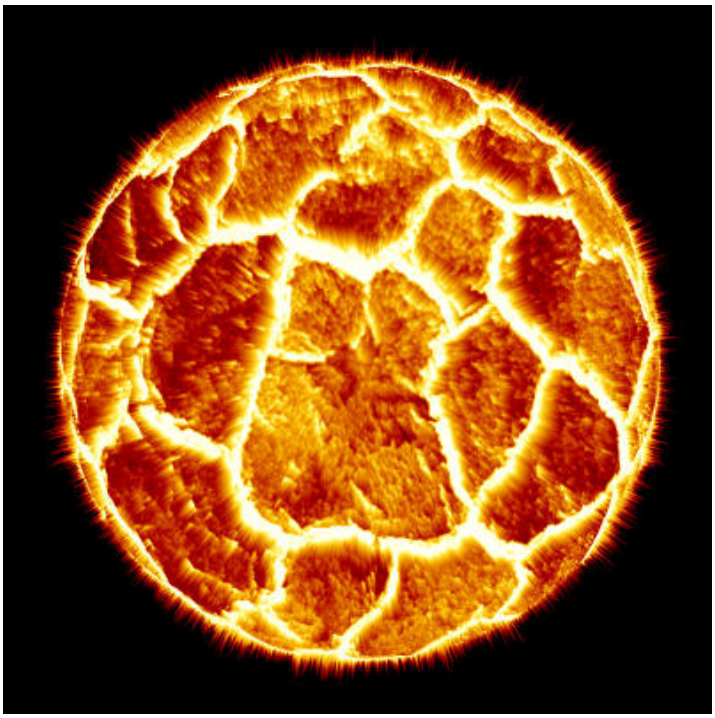
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Introduction to RSW

There's a palpable feeling of excitement today among people all over the world--an alien fleet has been orbiting the planet quietly for days. Is it friend or foe? No one knows for sure, but many are optimistic--hopeful for a new era of interspecies sharing and prosperity. And suddenly, a new fleet arrives! Then another, and another!

And then the word spreads of a new discovery about these alien fleets: the latest one to arrive is carrying what is unmistakably a **Planet Buster Bomb!** All hopes for peace are dashed, while the population runs for cover. But unfortunately for the gentle people of this peaceful little planet, there is no safe place to hide from a weapon such as this. . . .

Welcome to the universe of RSW, where the outcome of the story above rests on your shoulders. Are you a military genius, having lured your victims into a trap? Or a master of diplomacy and negotiation, with words of wisdom to calm your overly aggressive neighbors, or redirect their hostility elsewhere? Or perhaps you're skilled in misdirection and deceit, able to trick your enemies into attacking each other! In RSW, all of these kinds of players, and more, coexist and interact together--but only one will win.



What is RSW?

RSW is actually a family of related games. Some RSW games have fairly simple rules, and others are quite complex. Some games can play out very quickly--within an hour--but most RSW games play out slowly, over weeks, and can take multiple months to finish. You decide when you sign up for a game what kind of game you would like to play.

The simplest game, RSW Core, is a basic game of tactical resource distribution. Each player tries to capture the biggest part of the galaxy, using their fleets and ships to the best advantage.

Another game, RSW Classic, is a more complex game, with greater levels of sophistication. In RSW Classic, each player takes on the role of one of the following character types:

- The Emperor, who strives to own all worlds
- The Collector, who covets the strange artifacts deemed largely useless by others
- The Raider, who strikes fast and furious at their opponents
- The Trader, who earns profit from interstellar commerce
- The Positronix, who seeks the destruction of all human life
- The Missionary, who wishes to spread their truth across the galaxy
- --or additional, more advanced, character types

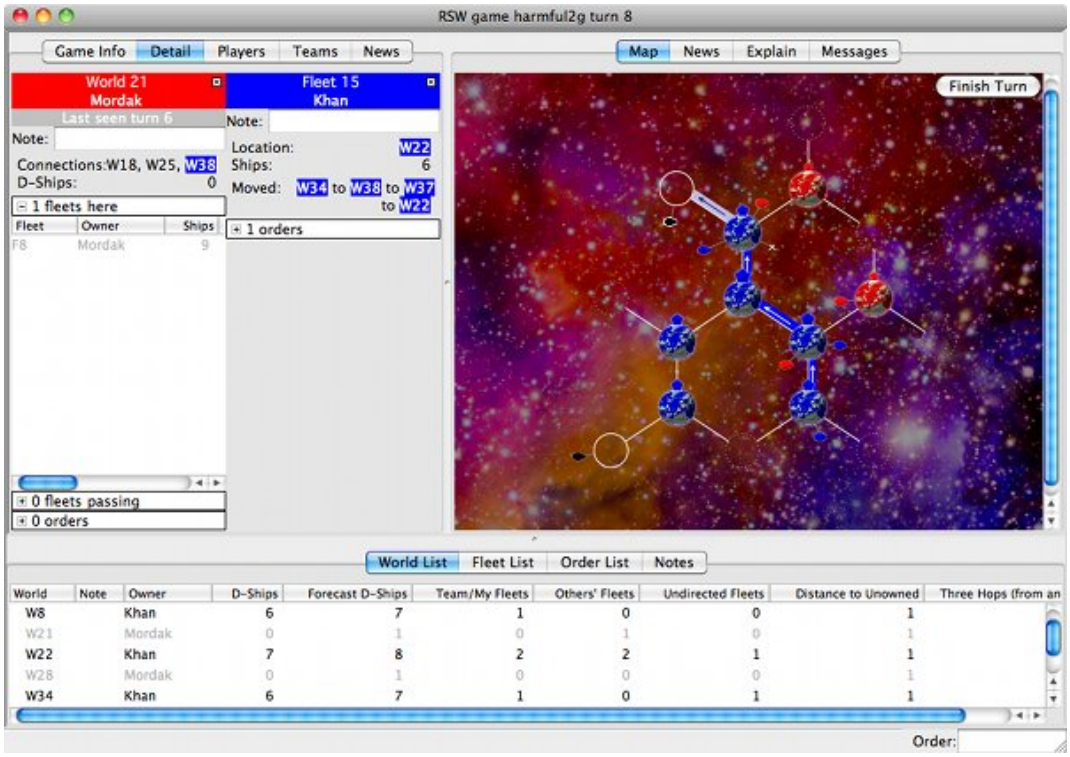
These different character types interact together in the galaxy in complex ways.

RSW Gameplay

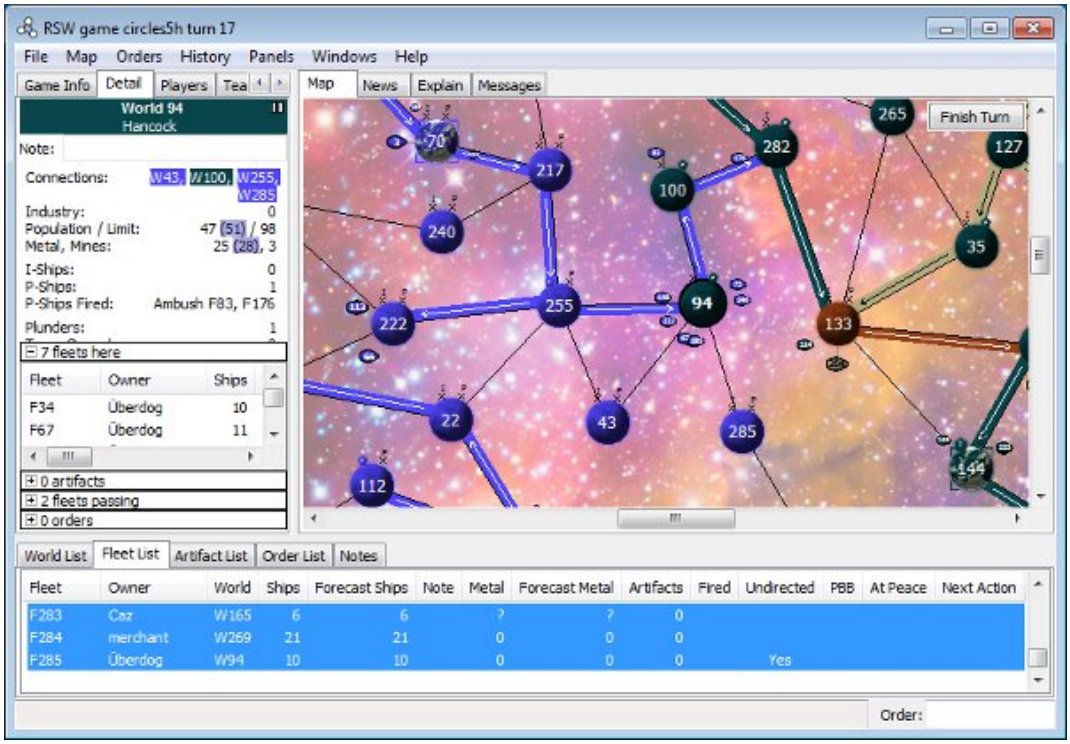
RSW is a cross-generation hybrid. It is a classic play-by-mail text game with a modern, graphical interface.

RSW is an homage to the play-by-mail games of the 1970's, some of the earliest computer-operated games ever played. These games were played by people who didn't necessarily have computers; players received their turn report printouts in the mail, studied them carefully and drew up their own maps by hand, and then wrote out an order sheet and mailed it back.

Although you can play RSW this way, via email or the web interface, almost everyone prefers to use the graphical interface instead. This is a separate, downloadable application called the RSW Client. Once you install and run the RSW Client, all of your games will automatically appear within the client, and you can see each of your game turns and the movements of the other players within the game. Instead of typing orders, you order your fleets to move by dragging them onto their destinations. You fire by dragging your fleet onto an opponent's fleet. Gameplay looks something like this:



Or, depending on the game, maybe more like this:



There are many different kinds of strategies for success in RSW. Some people excel at negotiations and diplomacy, while others emphasize military force and battle tactics. Still others are masters of misdirection and deceit. The galaxy has room for all kinds of players--which one will you be?

Getting Started

Ready to play? Great! There are two ways to play RSW:

- With friends. You can play a great RSW game with any number of players--two or more. Contact the friends you think might be interested in joining you in a game. You and your friends should decide amongst yourselves how many people are interested in playing, and what kind of game you'd like to play.

  When you're ready, click the Play button at the top of the page, and then click the red "New" button to add a new game. Follow the instructions to create a new game, then share the new game ID to all of your friends, and they can click the Game signup link to enter that game ID. The game has begun!
- With other RSW players. There is a community of players active in RSW, each with varying levels of experience. Some are new players, like yourself, while others might have dozens of games under their belt. What better way to learn the subtleties of the game, than to get involved in the game with an RSW expert?

  Click the Play button and scan the list of available games that other people have created. If one of them seems appealing, click on its game ID to sign up! If there aren't any available games that suit you, feel free to click the "New" button. Then wait for other players to sign up for your game. When the game's roster has filled up, the game will begin!

Note that there is no single-player version of the game. RSW is first and always a game between humans, built on the belief that there's no opponent more challenging, or more devious, than a human opponent. (You can, however, create a one-player game for yourself, just to try out the mechanics of the game while you wait for the real game to start.)

If you've decided to play an RSW Core game, see the sample walk-through and the Quick Strategy Guide for this game. If you're playing an RSW Classic game, it has its own sample walk-through and Strategy Guide.

General Topics

This section describes topics that relate to all kinds of RSW games.

- RSW Game Turns
- Signing Up for a Game
- Sending Messages
- A word about game ethics
- Designing RSW maps

To see the game in action, try the sample walk-through.

RSW Game Turns

RSW games are played in turns. Typically a game will require from 15 to 20 turns to play to completion. At each turn, the players can view their own worlds and whatever worlds their fleets are visiting. Generally, players don't have complete information about each other; all players see a different, possibly overlapping, portion of the galaxy.

All the players then have a certain amount of time, specified in the game parameters, to study the situation and determine a set of movement and combat orders to issue their worlds and fleets for next turn. Note that all the players work on their turns at the same time, independently of each other (though usually there is much negotiation that happens between players while they work out their turns).

RSW games are commonly played at the rate of about one turn per week, but any turn rate is possible; some people enjoy the excitement of playing games at the rate of one turn per day or faster. Generally, longer turn times allow for greater amounts of negotiation and diplomacy between players, so you can choose the turn rate that suits your playing style. It is possible to play a blitz game that rolls over a new turn every few minutes; games of this nature will typically involve very little diplomacy, and can be finished within an hour or two depending on the turn rate.

Out of kindness for your fellow RSW players, please do not sign up for a game unless you are ready to make the commitment to play it to completion. If you get halfway through a game and decide you need to drop out, it spoils the game for everyone.

The end of the game is specified in the game parameters. Usually the game is over when one of the players reaches a certain score. At that time, additional points are awarded based on various end-of-game bonuses, and the player with the highest score is declared the winner. The target score is determined at random when the game is created, and is not revealed to any of the players until the game is over. It will generally be somewhere in the range of 6,000 to 9,000 points.

Signing Up for a Game

When you are ready to play a game of RSW, you need to sign up for a game, and wait for other players to sign up as well.

From the RSW home page, click the "Play" button at the top of the page. If there are any pending games available currently ready for signup, they will be listed, and you can pick any one of them to sign up for.

If there aren't any games listed, or the none of the listed games are satisfactory, feel free to suggest a new game to add to the list. When you suggest a new game, you get to specify the terms of the game; and when other players sign up for the game, it will begin.

- Understanding the Game Description
- Game Types
- Game Variants
- Game Customizations
- Specialty Games
- Tournament Games
- Team Games
- Suggesting a New Game

Please don't sign up for a game without the intention of playing it all the way to completion. It spoils the game for other players when people sign up for a game and then drop out after a few turns. If you are not sure whether RSW is for you, then you may want to get together with a friend or two, and start a private game just between yourselves to try it out. You can even create a one-person game just for yourself, if you prefer, just to try out the mechanics of the game.

Understanding the Game Description

An available game description looks something like this:

steady2c is pending. Created 1 Dec 2009, last activity 2 Jan 2010.
Game type **Core**.
Runs every 2 days, excluding weekends.
3 players have joined, waiting to have 5-10 players.
Begins 15 Jan 2010 (if at least 2 more sign up).
Expires 18 Mar 2010.

This is the description for a hypothetical game, whose game ID is "steady2c". (Each game is assigned a unique, random game ID consisting of a common word followed by a digit and letter.) On the actual web page, the game ID will be a link; you should click on the game ID of your choice to sign up for that particular game.

In this example, you can see that the game steady2c is an RSW "Core" type game. This tells you the fundamental game rules. A "Core" game uses relatively simple game rules and is a good choice for a beginner. There are other game types that are possible too.

You can also see a description of the game's turn schedule. This particular example game runs every two weekdays. Therefore, if you were to sign up for this game, you should be prepared to enter turns two or three times a week.

Finally, the game description shows you the number of other players that have already signed up for this game, and the number of players that the game will require to fill it. This example game is waiting for at least two more players (a minimum of five), but it may run with as many as ten players, if enough people sign up before the start date of 15 Jan.

If at least the minimum number of players have signed up by the game's start date, the game will begin on that date. Once the start date passes, the game will remain available for more signups until the expiration date arrives, or the minimum number of people sign up, whichever comes first. If the expiration date arrives and the minimum number of players have not signed up, the game will be cancelled.

There might also be additional qualifications and customizations listed for a particular game. Here is an example of a more complex game description:

jealous8b is pending. Created 21 Dec 2009, last activity 3 Jan 2010.
Game type **Classic**.
Runs each Tue, Fri at 10:00 AM PST.
8 players have joined, waiting to have 12 players.
Expires 18 Feb 2010.
Jump start: players start out owning worlds.
Anonymous finish: players' names will not be revealed at game end.
This is a *no-communication* game.

There are quite a large number of possible game variants. Some people like to experiment with different variations on game rules and presentation, while others like to stick with the tried-and-true games.

Game Types

The RSW game type defines the basic nature of the game. Some games are simple, while others are much more complex. Some games favor intricate diplomacy and negotiations with other players, and others work better as simple command-and-conquer type battle games.

At the time of this writing, there are three different RSW game types available. More game types may become available later. Eventually, it may even be possible to define your own custom game types by writing Python code. (If you have a great idea for a new game type in the meantime, please feel free to contact the author with your suggestion.)

Core: This is a relatively straightforward game of command and conquest. Think of it in the same category as traditional board games you might already be familiar with, such as Risk. Click here for a deeper description of the RSW Core game type.

Classic: This variant is an homage to a classic play-by-mail game that debuted in the 1970's, known as Starweb. Game rules are moderately complex. This game should feel comfortable to players who have experience playing this other game in the past. Click here for a deeper description of the RSW Classic game type.

Advanced: This variant builds on the Classic game with additional character types and newly balanced scores. Click here for a deeper description of the RSW Advanced game type.

Game Variants

There are several game variants possible, on top of the basic game type and scheduling parameters. You can select any or all of these game variants when you suggest a game. Each of the selected game variants will be listed in brief in the available game description.

Variants you might see listed in a game description include the following:

This is a *private* game.

> This means that the game will not be listed on any public list of games, either before or after the game has started. Only people who know the game ID can sign up for the game, or see any details about it; and the only people who will know the game ID are the person who created the game, and whoever that person shared it with.
>
> Typically, people create a private game to enjoy a game among a specific group of people, without implicitly inviting the rest of the RSW community to play as well.

Tournament Game.

> Some games are *tournament games.* These games will contribute to each player's tournament rating, which is displayed on the leaderboard. See Tournament Games for more information.

Jump start: players start out owning worlds.

> Normally, each player starts out with only one world to their name, and the first three or four turns of the game are devoted to spreading out and discovering the worlds in the immediate vicinity of that one homeworld. Since these first few turns usually happen before any player has encountered another, it means RSW games get off to a fairly uninteresting start.
>
> This variant starts off each game by pre-assigning each player ownership of several worlds around their homeworld. Very often, the worlds immediately outside the visible spectrum of worlds will be owned by a neighbor, which means that players will usually encounter each other on turn 2. This makes the game get off to a roaring start more quickly. It does, however, eliminate some of the opportunities for players to differentiate themselves with their finely-tuned opening strategies.
>
> Note that, although the RSW server will make an effort to assign everyone a similar number of worlds to start with, there are no guarantees. Some unlucky players may begin the game with less than their fair share of worlds, while others may start out with more.

Anonymous finish: players' names will not be revealed at game end.

> Although all the players' identities are kept secret during gameplay, normally when the game is over the RSW server will reveal each player's identity to all of the other players in the game (as well as to any casual browsers, if it is not a private game).
>
> When this variant is enabled, players' identities are never revealed by the RSW server, at game end or at any other time. This might give some people an excuse to act especially ruthless, without much fear of retribution in future games.
>
> Don't confuse this option with a *no-communication* game, below.

Random character type assignment.

> Normally, players may choose their own character types when they sign up for a game. If this variant is enabled, players will sign up for the game without choosing a character type, and when the game begins, the server will assign each player a character type at random (according to the set of available character types for this game).

This is a *no-communication* game.

Diplomacy and player-to-player negotiations are a major part of the excitement of many RSW games. Sometimes, however, you just want to play a simple game of tactics and maneuvering, without committing yourself to the level of involvement necessary to maintain diplomatic relations with all of your neighbors.

One straightforward way to solve this is to play a *no-communication* game. In this kind of game, no communications are allowed between any players. A no-communication game therefore tends to require less time to play, and turns can be made much more quickly. Many people prefer to play no-communication games to reduce their time commitment to RSW.

In addition to disabling the in-game communication systems, the no-communication rule is enforced by scrambling the turn report for each player, so that the player handles, and the world and fleet numbers, appear different for each player. This is intended to make it difficult for players to cheat the no-communication rule by comparing notes out-of-game.

Some people refer to a no-communication game as an "anonymous" game, for historical reasons, even though every game is technically anonymous. Don't confuse a no-communication game with an anonymous finish game (above).

Opponents' character types will be revealed.

Normally, in games which involves characters of different types, the RSW server will not reveal the character type of the other players you encounter. You must ask your neighbors to tell you their character type, or you must deduce it on your own somehow.

If this variant is selected, then the RSW server will eliminate this guesswork, and simply tell each player the character type of all the other players they meet. This may eliminate part of the excitement of a normal game, but on the other hand can be a very useful thing to facilitate cooperation, especially in a no-communication game.

This is a *multi-position* game: 2 positions each.

This variant allows each player to sign up for and play multiple game positions within the same game. You may also see 3-position, 4-position, or any greater number of multi-position games as well.

In a multi-position game, each player's final score is the *lowest* of all of the game positions they are (or were) responsible for. There is no guarantee that a player's multiple positions will start out the game near each other (and, conversely, no guarantee that they will be far apart). However, each of a player's initial multiple positions are considered to have already met each other at game start, which allows the player to exchange gifts between their different positions from turn one.

Multiple positions are kept secret.

In a normal multi-position game, the RSW server will inform all of the other players automatically about the set of positions controlled by a single player. If this game variant is selected, then the server will *not* reveal this information, and it is up to the players to determine which game positions are controlled by the same player.

Game Customizations

Like the basic game variants, RSW game customizations can be declared when the game is suggested. The game customizations go further, and define changes that might influence gameplay or game rules in more subtle ways than the basic game variants.

Character Types

Some RSW game types require players to choose one of several available different character types. Normally, the full set of character types, as defined by the game type, is available to each player for signup, with an equal number of each character type. It is possible to create a game that

involves a smaller selection of character types, or a nonequal number of the different character types.

For instance, someone might suggest a game that is entirely Raiders. Or you might sign up for a game that involves one Trader and fourteen Missionaries.

Initial Galaxy Parameters

There are a handful of tuning parameters that are normally chosen randomly at the time the game starts, to add a bit of variety to each game and make the games more interesting. The precise set of these parameters depends on the game type, but generally there are parameters that determine things like the number of worlds per player, the number of connections between worlds, or the number of available fleets or artifacts in the game, or even the number of black holes in the galaxy.

It's possible to suggest a game with one or more of these random parameters fixed instead of randomly selected. You could, for instance, use this to make a tournament game, where all the parameters are their standard, average value; or you could intentionally set any of the parameters to extreme values to change the necessary gameplay strategy and possibly favor different character types over others.

Advanced Game Customizations

In addition to all the customizations described above, almost any numeric parameter described in the game rules can be customized to your liking. For instance, you could change the number of fleets, or the amount of industry, that each player finds at their homeworld at game start. Or you could change the ratio of ships required for a Raider to perform a successful Commandeer, or the number of points awarded to a Positronix for dropping a PBB.

Furthermore, it's possible to make these changes specific to one character type and not to others (maybe you feel a Trader should begin the game with 15 industry, while other players start with the standard 30). And, by combining these parameters in new ways, you can even create new character types (for instance, a Robotic Missionary) to add to the available types for signup.

Specialty Games

All the games listed on the signup page have been suggested by RSW users, like yourself. Some of these games may be very traditional RSW games, while others might have been customized considerably from the standard RSW game rules.

Hopefully, any new customizations will result in a new, exciting game. However, it remains possible that a user will suggest a game that is flawed or otherwise somehow not quite the experience that you might have been hoping for.

To help protect new, inexperienced RSW users from accidentally signing up for this kind of an experimental game, the RSW server will automatically detect when a game has been modified significantly from the standard game rules, and mark it as a *specialty* game. This designation simply means that the game parameters deserve a close look before you decide to sign up.

This doesn't mean that a specialty game won't be fun! Quite the contrary: no doubt, the best game rules are yet to be invented. We encourage our users to experiment with new and unusual variations to the standard game rules; if a particularly exciting rule variation is discovered, we may choose to incorporate it into the standard rule set.

If this is your first time playing RSW, though, you may be best off signing up for a game *not* marked as a specialty game, to give you a chance to experience the original game rules first.

Tournament Games

Some games are *Tournament games.* These games are special: they contribute to each player's tournament rating, which is shared with the world on the RSW Leaderboard page. There are a handful of different kinds of tournament games that can be created. Customizations are not allowed; tournament games are played according to a standard set of rules.

The rating number shown for each player on the leaderboard loosely represents how well they have played recently. It is similar to the Elo system for rating chess players: a rating of 1500 is average. If the player has been winning consistently, they will have a rating higher than 1500; if the player has been losing, they will have a rating lower than 1500.

If you have not yet entered a tournament game, your rating is 0. For the first five tournament games, your rating will remain low, but it will increase by about 300 points per game until you have played your 5th tournament game. Thereafter it will hover around 1500 points according to how well you have been playing.

The tournament rating is based solely on your final ranking against the other players in the game, not directly on your score. Your rating increases if you score higher than most other players in the game, and it decreases if most other players score higher than you. The actual numeric difference in the score is not important, however; only the fact that one score is higher than anoter.

There is also a separate leaderboard for each character type in a particular game. For the purpose of computing the type-specific rating, your ranking is compared only to other players of the same character type in the same game. For instance, if you are playing a Raider, your Raider rating will go up if you scored higher than the other Raiders in the game. If you are the only player of your character type in a particular game, your type-specific rating will not change.

Team Games

In a Team game, the players are divided into two or more teams. Some games allow you to choose the team you want to join when you sign up, while others will randomly assign you to a team automatically. You cannot change teams during the game.

Each turn, the server will deliver to you not only your own turn report, but also the turn reports of all of your teammates. You can also see the orders that your teammates are entering as they go, so you can work closely with your teammates to choose the best strategy for all of you. And you should indeed plan carefully, since your final score will depend on the scores of your teammates--in a Team game, all the members of a team win or lose as a group. The teams are ranked on the final scoreboard based on the average score of all members on the team.

Even if a player drops out of the game, your team is still responsible for that player's score. So it is beholden on you to find someone to take over for a dropped player as quickly as possible.

Your individual score still matters, too, because within a team, players are ranked according to their relative score. So to top the winner list in a team game, you need to be the highest-scoring player on the highest-scoring team.

Teams have names. In some Team games, the team names are pre-assigned by the person who created the game; but if the name has not been assigned, all players on a team get a chance to name their team

when the game begins. Choose a good name to inspire your teammates to greatness! Decide amongst yourselves what the team name should be, and at least one player on the team should submit the team name using either the TN=xxx order, or via the "Set color/name" button in the Teams panel within the RSW Client.

Suggesting a New Game

If none of the available games under the "Game signup" link appeal to you, feel free to suggest a new game more to your liking. You can do this by clicking the red "New" button on the Game signup page.

You are allowed to specify all of the game options, beginning with the basic game type, the number of players in the game, and the turn schedule. You can also further specify any game variants and customizations you deem appropriate.

When you are satisfied with the game you are suggesting, click the "Create Game" button to make the game available for yourself and others to sign up and play. Note that you can bookmark the page with the "Create Game" button before you press it, in case you decide to create another game with the same parameters later.

If you want to start a game with no waiting, arrange with your friends the game parameters and the number of players in the game. Then create the game with the agreed number of players and invite all of your friends to sign up for the game immediately.

Sending messages

Keeping your communication channels open with the other players in the game is vital to a successful RSW strategy. RSW provides a robust in-game messaging system for communicating with the other players. This messaging system is very similar to ordinary email; you can send messages to other players you meet in the RSW games you are involved in, and the messages you receive and send are collected in your in-game mailbox.

When you write a new message the default is to deliver it immediately, but it is also possible to hold messages for automatic delivery at the start of the next turn. Normally, you can only write messages to other players you have met in the game and whose player handle you know; but it is also possible to deliver a message to everyone in the game at once, regardless of whether you have met them yet in-game or not.

From the RSW client, click on the "Messages" tab to access the messages for a particular game. If you are playing a multi-position game, there will be a separate page for each position you are playing, selectable with the tabs on the left.

The default message list is "Received and Sent Messages". This includes messages sent by you, as well as messages received by you, together in the same list. You may also switch the message list to "Held Messages", which shows messages that have not yet been delivered, but are being held for automatic delivery at the start of the next turn.

From the web interface, you can access the list of received and sent messages from the navigation links at the top of the page. Messages that are held for delivery will appear within your order list, in the yellow text block on the main game page.

There is no mechanism for deleting messages. All messages are saved for the duration of the game.

Email relay

It is possible to configure RSW to forward any messages you receive directly to your email address. You may then reply to these messages as if they were ordinary email messages, using your favorite email client; and they will be delivered to the other players, as if you had responded in-game. This is done without revealing your email address to the other players in the game.

This magic is possible because the RSW server creates a special email address for each player in the game, and inserts this email address in the To: and From: fields of the email messages it forwards to you. When you reply to one of these forwarded emails, the message is received by the RSW server, which will strip out your actual email address and replace it with your special RSW email address, and then send it on to the intended recipients.

In this way you can carry on a dialog via email with as many players as you wish, while keeping your true identity hidden for as long as you care to. (Of course, you are free to reveal your actual email address or other contact information if you choose.)

Note: Be sure you disable any automatic "signature" or any other self-identifying features of your email software, if you intend to remain anonymous! RSW will not strip out any part of the message text itself; all it can do is remove your email address from the headers.

Email attachments

When you use your email client to send messages to other players, you may include any attachments you like (for instance, it might be useful to send xml files or map images to your allies). These attachments will be preserved in the email copy of your message as it is delivered to your recipients, but the attachments will not be saved in the RSW database, so they will *only* be available in email; they cannot be retrieved via the in-game web interface or the RSW Client.

Play by E-mail

Although most people prefer to use the RSW Client or the web interface to play, it is also possible to play the game entirely via email. You can use simple email commands to do almost anything that you can do via the web interface; for instance, you can list the currently available games, join a pending game, receive your turn reports, and even submit your orders, all from your email client.

To do this, send just the world "hello" in an email message to the RSW server at rsw@rswgame.com. This message must consist of just the word "hello" on a line by itself, in the body of the message (not the subject line). If you send anything else, the RSW server may assume you are a spammer and ignore the message. In response to the word "hello", the RSW server will return an automatic reply that will give you further instructions.

This is most useful for users who prefer to use a third-party client to play RSW--particularly a client that is designed primarily for use via email. Visually impaired users may also find the email interface easier to navigate. However, any user who for some reason prefers sending commands via email over using the web interface is welcome to use this system.

A word about game ethics

For the most part, the game rules exactly specify what is allowed and what is not allowed in RSW. If the game rules forbid it, you shouldn't do it; and if the game rules don't mention it, there's no official compunction not to do it.

This extends to behavior such as deliberately misleading, or outright lying, to other players in the game. There are no rules against it, so it is completely up to you to decide how honest you wish to be to your allies. Similarly, it is incumbent on you to decide how much to trust the information you have received in turn from your allies.

There is also no particular rule forbidding communication outside of the game (except for no-communication games). If you find it more convenient to use the telephone, or to make your plans head-to-head over a burger and fries, go to it. On the other hand, if you prefer to remain anonymous and keep all your communications within the in-game channels, that's fine too.

No-communication games are different. If you sign up to play a no-communication game, you should be prepared to play it from beginning to end with *no* attempt to communicate with the other players in the game. No communication means just what it says--no attempt to identify the other players you meet, no attempt to coordinate plans, not even an agreement of mutual non-aggression (beyond what you can achieve through gifting and other in-game tokens of friendship). The reason no-communication games exist is to create a game of pure tactics and strategy, absent the complexity that negotiation and alliances add to the game. If you don't want to play a game without coordinating with your allies, then don't sign up for a no-communication game.

We *do* also require you to keep all deceit strictly within the context of the game. We specifically forbid attempts to deceive or attack the game server itself. Attempting to hack into the server, or into someone's personal email, to obtain another player's game report or some other in-game advantage is not only wrong, but also illegal. Sending fraudulent email is another example of an ethically and legally questionable act.

We also object to creating more than one RSW account for yourself. There is no reason for any person to have more than one RSW account, other than to sign up both accounts for the same game, which is cheating--it gives you an unfair advantage over the other players in the game. Because RSW accounts are free and can be created without restriction, it's impossible for us to enforce this rule and prevent people from creating multiple accounts, so instead we must appeal to people's innate sense of honesty and fair play. If you want to play multiple positions in the same game, you should sign up for a multi-position game, which gives all players the same advantages. But a single-position game is meant to be played by one player per position, and we urge you to resist the temptation to try to cheat that rule.

Designing RSW maps

RSW supports two different kinds of game maps: computer-generated, and human-designed. The human-designed maps are selected from a library of maps contributed by RSW users.

You can contribute your own maps to the library if you like. The RSW client provides a module for designing maps and submitting them to the server. As a general rule of thumb, you should design maps that have:

- 13 - 20 worlds per player
- 2.5 - 5 average connections per world
- No outlying (disconnected) worlds

Generally, you should design a family of similar maps of different sizes, to support different numbers of players; but you may design maps that only support a specific number of players if you prefer.

To generate a map, select "New RSW map" from the "File" menu of the RSW game list window, within the client. This opens up a blank gray window within which you may start drawing your map. The controls are similar to the map-editing controls within the game, with a few additions. In particular, you should use:

- Right-click to add the first world.
- Shift-drag to connect existing worlds, or to create and connect to a new world.
- Shift-drag again to disconnect worlds.
- Control-click, or draw a circle, to select multiple worlds.
- Control-X, Control-C, Control-V for Cut, Copy, and Paste.
- Copy / Paste followed by drag-and-drop, to build up repeating patterns.
- Right-click to set homeworld, passage, or treasure world states.

Declaring homeworlds is optional. If you mark no worlds as homeworlds, then the RSW server will automatically select homeworlds for the players in the game that are approximately evenly spaced across your map. If you mark at least one homeworld, then you must mark all the possible homeworlds; and in this case, the RSW server will only select from the marked worlds. Marking homeworlds may limit the number of players that can use your map, since a map cannot be used in a game with more players than the map has homeworlds.

"Passage" worlds are worlds that are critical to keep clear passage, e.g. small bottlenecks between large sections. The server will never place a black hole or a homeworld at a passage world. Most maps do not require marking passage worlds explicitly (the server will never place a black hole where it will completely separate off a section of the galaxy anyway).

Treasure worlds are a further optional feature. Some specialty maps may declare one or more "treasure worlds", worlds that are out of the way or hard to get to, but provide some in-game reward for players who discover them, such as extra industry or artifacts. You can declare Gold, Silver, or Bronze treasure worlds; the precise meanings of these treasures for a particular game can be specified in the custom game settings. Most maps do not use treasure worlds.

When you are done designing a map, you should give it a title, and a set of tags. Tags are individual words that are used to select the map into a game. Each game is set to use a particular "map set", and a map set is a set of words--it means all of the maps that share all of the tags named by the map set.

The following tags are standard:

- *core* - this map is a good default map for a Core game.
- *classic* - this map is a good default map for a Classic game.
- *advanced* - this map is a good default map for an Advanced game.
- *other* - this map is not a good default map, but it can be explicitly named.
- *levels* - this map uses multiple levels.
- *conflict* - this map is designed to promote conflict.
- *treasure* - this map uses treasure worlds.

- *secret* - this map will never be revealed to users.

You may add your own tags in addition to these. Tags should be entered in English. In general, you should add at least one custom tag to each family of similar maps, if you create multiple maps in different sizes--this allows you to select the entire family into a single map set. Also, you should consider adding your own name as a tag to all of the maps you design, so that someone can select all of your maps as a map set if they wish.

The RSW Core Game Type

The RSW Core game is a basic game of expansion and strategic placement. It serves as a good introduction to RSW for newcomers to the game, while it continues to be an enjoyable game for experienced players.

Many of the complexities of RSW Classic are absent from the RSW Core game. There are no character types to worry about, no metal to haul, no population or industry, and no artifacts. The game boils down to just worlds, fleets, and ships, and everyone starts out on an equal footing.

Each player gains points strictly for owning worlds; the player who captures and keeps the most worlds from the other players will win the game. Specifically, each player earns 20 points per turn for each world that they own at the end of that turn. All worlds are the same.

Each player starts the game with one world and five fleets.

- Quick Strategy Guide
- A Sample Walk-Through
- The Game Rules in Depth

Quick Strategy Guide: RSW Core

There are three key resources you will need to acquire to succeed in RSW Core:

- **Worlds.** You need to own a certain number of worlds to keep you well-stocked in ships. Each world that you own produces at least one ship every turn, so the more worlds you have, the more ships you control. Also, you get 20 points per turn for each world that you own, so owning worlds is the key to winning the game in more ways than one. You acquire an initial collection of worlds by being the first player to visit them in the first three or four turns of the game--this is why it is important to expand as quickly as possible, and reach as many worlds as possible before other players get there first.
- **Fleets.** There are only a fixed number of fleets in the game, and you have to acquire them, the same way you acquire worlds--that is, you have to be the first player to find them, before someone else gets to them first.
- **Ships.** Ships are military muscle. The more ships you can put on a fleet, the more powerful the fleet becomes. If you want to overwhelm your opponents with force, you will need lots of fleets, with lots of ships each. You can transfer ships from your worlds to your fleets as the ships are built.

You begin every RSW Core game with one world and five fleets, with six ships on each fleet. The first turn is always pretty much the same--you should send at least one fleet to each of the worlds connected to your homeworld.

Capturing Worlds and Fleets

On the second turn, you will have captured each of the worlds you sent a fleet to. Hopefully, you will also have captured a few more fleets--there are empty fleets scattered around throughout the galaxy. You probably won't have encountered another player yet, so your second turn is usually always the same too: transfer a few ships from your fleets to any new fleets you have captured, and then move fleets out to any new outlying worlds you can reach. Again, move at least one fleet to each world you can connect to, if at all possible--remember, you want to expand as quickly as possible, and claim as many worlds as you can reach, before someone else claims these worlds first.

Here we should pause a moment to point out a few important rules of the game:

- Ships can be transferred at will, fleet-to-fleet, fleet-to-world, or world-to-fleet.
- You need to have at least one ship on a fleet to keep and use the fleet.
- Each world that you own will produce at least one ship per turn for as long as you own it. Maintaining ownership of adjacent worlds will produce even more ships. Ships remain on the world (as D-Ships) until you transfer them to a fleet.

Managing Your Ships

Owning dozens of worlds, and therefore producing dozens of new D-Ships each turn, won't help you if you just leave the D-Ships on the worlds.

You need to keep your fleets stocked with ships in order to dominate your neighbors. This means visiting each of your worlds from time to time and transferring ships from the D-Ships there onto your fleet(s). You can either bring fleets back from the front lines to do this, or you can build up a supply chain of fleets to bring ships out to support the fleets that you keep on the front lines.

Capturing Opponent's Worlds and Fleets

Once an opponent owns a world, you will no longer capture it simply by showing up. You will have to fire your fleet at the D-Ships at a world, destroying them, to capture it (and you will capture it then only if you are the only player with fleets there). Similarly, you can fire at an opponent's fleet, and if you destroy all of the ships on it, and there are no other players with fleets there, you will capture the fleet from your opponent.

Encountering Other Players

Usually you will meet your first opponent on the third or fourth turn. Sometimes you will encounter multiple opponents at once. These other players will be trying to expand their empire as quickly as possible, just as you are, and your presence has just marked the edge of their expansion.

Once you have encountered your first neighbor--usually on the third or fourth turn--you will need to change your strategy to adapt. Is your new neighbor warlike and aggressive, or passive and easily subdued? Or maybe they are just trying to lure you into a trap while they position their other fleets to strike at your flank! Perhaps you can form an alliance with your nearest neighbor to take out a common enemy.

A Sample Walk-Through: RSW Core

In the following few pages, we'll illustrate playing the first few turns of a sample RSW Core game.

There are two fundamentally different interfaces to use to play RSW: you can play it via the web interface, which presents a strictly text-based interface to the game, or via the downloadable RSW Client, which is graphical. We will illustrate the graphical client interface here.

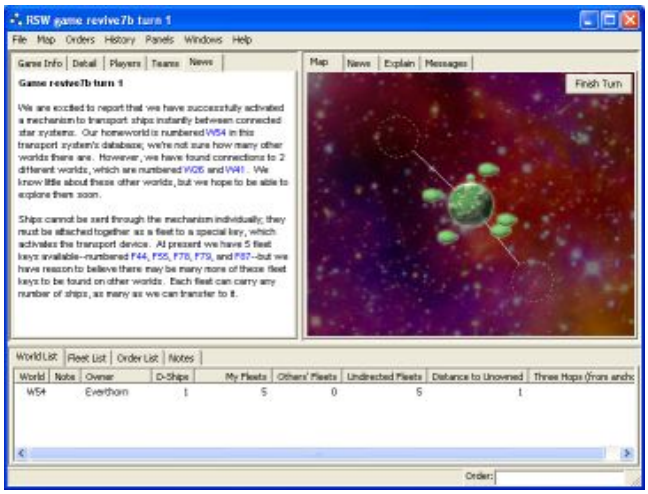
If this is your first time playing RSW, we recommend you download and use the RSW Client to play. The RSW Client provides a much friendlier user interface to the same game data; and is usually a much better choice for a beginner.

- The First Turn
- The Second Turn
- The Third Turn

The First Turn

Suppose you have signed up for an RSW Core game, and the game has just begun.

When you next start the RSW Client, the new game will automatically download into the client, and when you click on it, you'll see something like this:



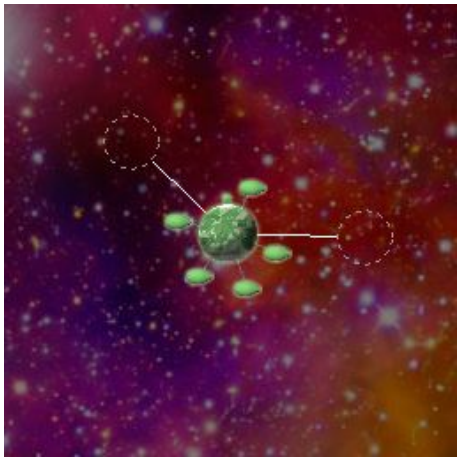
This is the Game Window, and this is where you will do most of your interaction with the game. The Game Window consists of three different panels, each of which contains several tabs across the top, allowing you to select between the various pages of information available for each panel.

You can click through the various tabs to see what they are, but for a Core game, almost all of your interaction will be via the Map panel, in the upper-right. This is where you can see and control your worlds and fleets. The other panels are useful for learning more details about your game view, but they aren't as necessary for the Core game; they're designed for the more complex RSW games, such as the RSW Classic game.

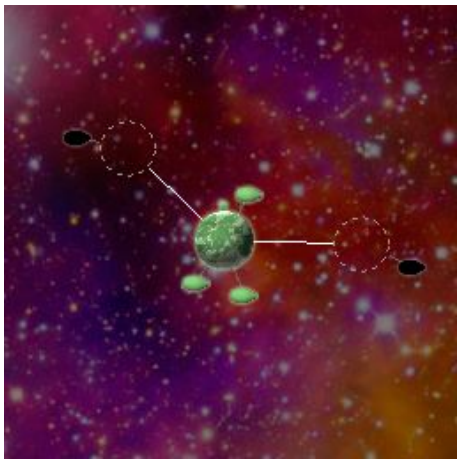
Take a closer look at the map. The colored circle in the center is your starting world. It connects to, in this example, two additional worlds, which are drawn as empty dashed circles here because you don't yet know anything about them.

There are also five fleets in orbit about your world, drawn as little football-shaped objects, plus a small symbol on the top of the world that represents the D-Ships based there.

In some games, the worlds are automatically placed according to the map data provided by the server, and cannot be moved around by you (unless you turn off "Freeze Worlds" in the menu). In other games, the map data is hidden, and you have to move the worlds around yourself to minimize accidental overlap and see everything clearly:



Now, in RSW Core, your first turn should generally be to explore all of the worlds connected to your starting world. So, since in this example there are two connected worlds, we will order one fleet to move to each of them, by clicking on the fleet and dragging it to the world. This will look like this:



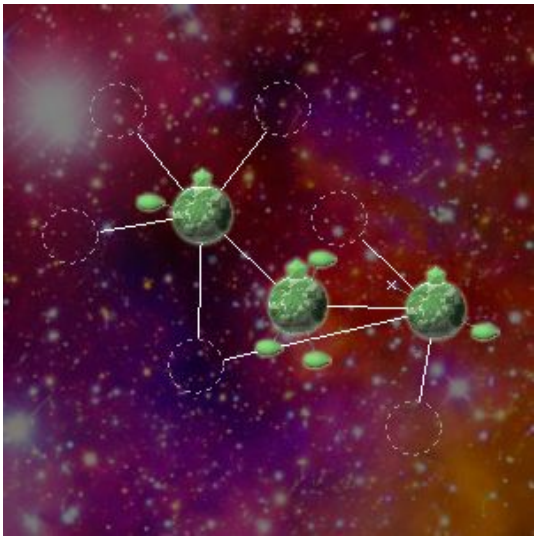
The fleets that we have given movement orders to are now drawn in black, to indicate that they have received a movement or combat order. (Each fleet can only be given one movement or combat order per turn.)

If we had had more than two connected worlds, we would have moved fleets to them as well. You shouldn't leave any worlds unexplored if you can help it.

Finally, you need to submit your orders to the server, to indicate you're done with the turn. Click the "Finish Turn" button in the map window, and then sit back and wait for the other players to submit their orders too.

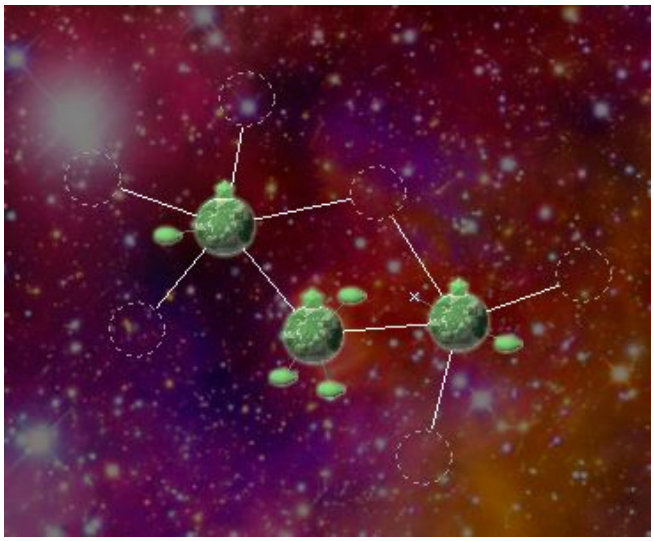
The Second Turn

When all the other players in the game have entered their orders and the first turn runs, the RSW Client will automatically download the second turn. Now your map includes information about the new worlds you visited:



Since you were the first player to visit each of these new worlds, you automatically captured them, so now they're drawn in the same color that the RSW client has chosen to represent you (green, in this example).

In this particular sample game, the map data is not provided by the server, and you'll need to reposition the worlds yourself to make things a little clearer. The initial position of the newly-discovered map worlds is somewhat random, and it can end up looking like a chaotic mess. It shouldn't be too difficult to find a new arrangement in which everything is clear:



Tip: to make it easier to arrange the worlds, temporarily turn off the "Show Fleets" option in the map menu. When you have the worlds arranged as you like them, turn on "Show Fleets" again. You might also want to turn on "Freeze Worlds" to prevent you from accidentally moving them around.

There is a new detail now: on one of our new worlds, we have also encountered an empty fleet key. This is drawn as an X, because it has no ships on it. (There are other drawing modes in which an X means something else, and you can change these modes in the Map menu, but this is the initial, default behavior.)

This new empty fleet key is good news for you! This fleet can be immediately pressed into your service. But you need to have at least one ship on each fleet in order to use it, so you should transfer ships from your other fleet which is there at a the same world. Drag your fleet onto the X to transfer ships to it. Alternatively, you can transfer ships from the world's D-Ships instead, by dragging the world's pentagon symbol onto the X.

In fact, you probably *should* transfer ships from D-Ships to a fleet at any world you can, by dragging the pentagon on the world onto one of your fleets. Each world produces at least one D-Ship every turn that you own it, and this is your only source of fresh ships, which will help you out in future battles. You will need to develop a strategy that involves revisiting each of your worlds from time to time, to pick up all of the D-Ships there.

Now, we see that we have additional connections to several new worlds. We should send a fleet to each of these worlds, if we have enough fleets. Note that a fleet can travel through multiple worlds in one jump--up to three worlds at once--so at this point, we can move any of our fleets to any of the worlds. In this example, we have just exactly enough fleets, if we take advantage of the extra fleet key we just acquired.

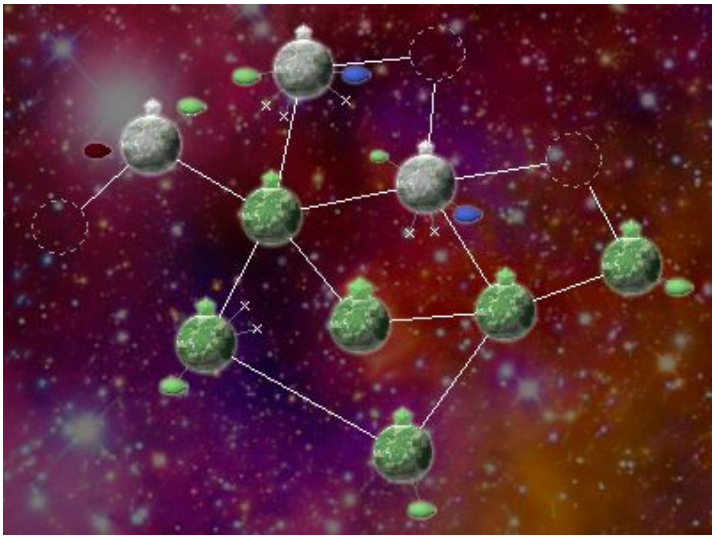
The map now looks like this:



As before, click the "Finish Turn" button, and wait for the other players.

The Third Turn

On the third turn, the map looks like this:



You have encountered two other players! The RSW Client has picked a random color to assign to each new player, which in this example is blue for one player and dark purple for the other.

The worlds at which you encountered other players are, in this example, unowned by anyone, and are colored white to indicate this. (If they had already been captured by the other player, the worlds would be colored in the player's color.)

Note also that there are new empty fleet keys at several worlds, drawn as X's. The keys at the world you captured by yourself (the green world) are yours to use. The keys at worlds at which you met another player, however (white worlds), are not available--you can't transfer ships to them until you're the only player at that world.

Now, you have an interesting choice. Should you send a message to your new neighbors, offering peace and alliance? Or should you immediately fire upon them both, and attempt to seize one or all of these worlds for yourself? Or maybe you should form an alliance with one player to defeat the other?

If you decide in favor of war, you can fire your fleets at any purple or blue target of your choosing (at the same world), by dragging the fleet onto the target. To fire at an opponent's fleet, drag your fleet onto their fleet. To fire at the world itself, drag your fleet onto the pentagon that represents the D-Ships for that world. (There's no point in doing this until later turns, though, when you encounter worlds actually owned by another player.) If you successfully destroy all of the ships on a fleet, or all of the D-Ships on the world, that fleet or world will become unowned and unusable. When you are the only player remaining at the world, you will capture the world and all of the unowned fleets!

If you decide to take the road of peace, you may choose to send a message to your neighbor to hammer out the terms (or, if necessary, to bargain for your own safety). Right-click on a world or fleet to send a message to the world's owner. Or visit the messages tab and compose a message directly.

The game has begun. Good luck!

The Game Rules in Depth: RSW Core

The rules for playing RSW Core are relatively simple, especially compared to the other RSW game types, but there are several subtle points. We recommend you skim through these chapters first to get an overall feel for the game, then come back when you need to consult some particular section in more detail.

1. Worlds
    a. D-Ship Production
2. Fleets
    a. Ships
    b. Transfers
    c. Movement
3. Combat
    a. Ambush
4. Miscellaneous Rules
    a. Capturing Worlds and Fleets
    b. Teammates
    c. Order Codes

Worlds

The galaxy consists of a number of worlds, most of which are initially unowned by any player. The precise number of worlds varies per game (and is loosely based on the number of players); in any particular game, there may be dozens of worlds, or there may be hundreds.

Most worlds are connected to two, three, or four other worlds. Some worlds might have only one connection; some may have as many as five or six. Ultimately, all worlds are interconnected in a single contiguous Web.

In RSW Core, unlike in some other RSW variants, all worlds are the same. Every world that you own is worth 20 points to you each turn that you own it, and every world will produce ships each turn that you own it.

The ships that accumulate on a world will remain in defense of the world itself (they're called "defensive ships" or "D-Ships" for short), until you transfer some or all of them onto an orbiting fleet. It is also possible to fire D-Ships directly at an enemy fleet at the same world--see combat for more.

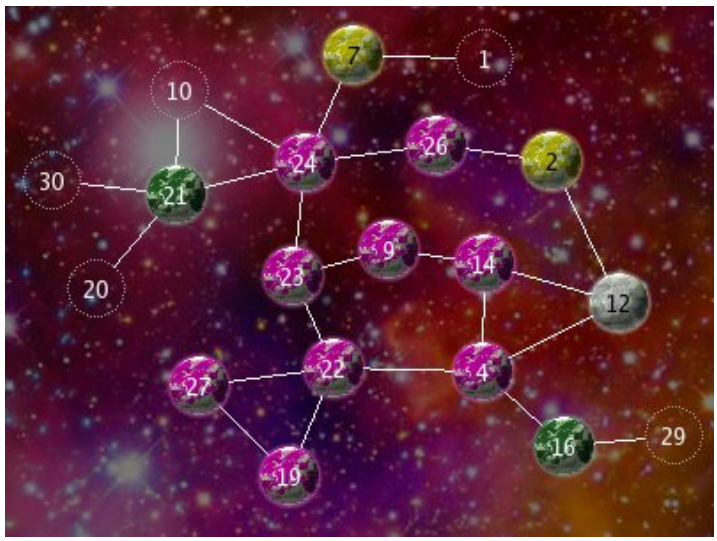
As you visit new, unowned worlds in the galaxy, you will automatically plant your flag on them, so to speak, and claim them as your own. The exact rules of ownership are a little more complex, but in general, you will own any world that you are the first to visit.

D-Ship Production

Every world that you own will produce at least one new D-Ship every turn. However, if you own all of the worlds surrounding a given world, it will produce more than one D-Ship, depending on how far it is from there to the nearest world you don't own.

To put the rule precisely, for each of your worlds, count the number of steps from that world to the nearest world *not* owned by you. That's the number of D-Ships that world will produce each turn.

Consider the following sample map:



In this map, you own all of the magenta worlds. Worlds 2 and 7 are owned by one of your opponents, and worlds 21 and 16 are owned by another opponent. World 12 is not owned by anyone.

Worlds 24, 26, 14, and 4 all connect directly to a world not owned by you. These worlds will therefore produce just one D-Ship next turn.

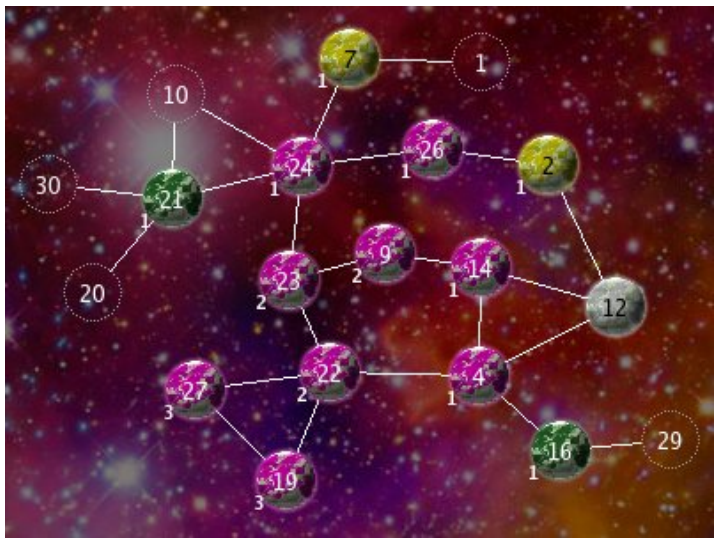
However, worlds 9, 22, and 23 will produce *two* D-Ships next turn, because they connect only to worlds that you own--from these worlds, you must travel two hops to reach a world you don't own.

Furthermore, worlds 19 and 27 will produce *three* D-Ships next turn, because they are three hops away from the nearest world that you do not own.

If you were to successfully capture both worlds 12 and 16, then worlds 19 and 27 would start to produce *four* D-Ships per turn, because that would be the new minimum distance to a world you don't own.

Automatically Showing Production Numbers

You don't need to count up the distance to the nearest unowned world yourself. Just pick "Show distance to unowned" from the Map menu, and the RSW Client will calculate this number for each world, and write it to the world's lower left. It looks like this:



Fleets

A fleet key is necessary to send ships through a connection to another world. You can attach as many ships to a fleet key as you like; these ships then move and fire as a unit.

Ships can be built and destroyed, but the fleet key is indestructible. In general, we use the word "fleet" throughout the game to refer to a fleet key and all of its ships, even when there are no ships at all on the key.

In addition to the five fleet keys that you own at the beginning of the game, there are several more empty, unowned fleet keys scattered throughout the galaxy. The total number of fleets is fixed in a particular game (fleet keys cannot be created or destroyed), and the exact number depends on the number of players.

As with worlds, though the precise rules of ownership are more complex, in general, you will automatically claim as your own any empty fleet keys you find at the worlds you are the first to visit.

- Ships
- Transfers
- Movement

Ships

Ships define the capacity and strength of your fleets. You can transfer ships between fleets, or from D-Ships to fleets or back again. You must have at least one ship on each fleet key in order to keep ownership of it, but there is no upper limit to the number of ships you may put on any one fleet.

The ships define military power: each ship on a fleet can fire one shot at your enemies, and it takes two shots to destroy each enemy ship. Thus, the more ships you have, the more firepower you have; and the more firepower it will take to destroy your fleet.

In order to capture an opponent's fleet, you must fire at and destroy all of the ships on it, and also be the only player with fleets remaining at that same world.

Transfers

You can freely move ships around between D-Ships and all the fleets that are present at a world at the beginning of a turn. This is called a transfer.

Transferring ships to a fleet does not capture the fleet. Instead, transferring ships to a fleet you don't own will just give the ships away. Sometimes you want to do this (for instance, to give ships to an ally). If you transfer ships to an unowned, empty fleet key, you will create a neutral fleet, which is almost always a mistake.

Movement

Fleets may move to any directly connected world, or simultaneously through two or three consecutive connections. For example, if F13 is at W36, which has a connection to W25; and W25 has a connection to W2, and W2 has a connection to W10, then F13 can move in one turn through W25 and

W2 to end up at W10.

When you move a fleet through multiple connections at once like this, you will get a complete report of any worlds you pass completely through, as well as the world you left and the world you arrived at.

You cannot both move and fire a fleet in the same turn.

Fleet movement takes place after transfers, and at the same time as combat.

Combat

Any fleet or D-Ships may fire at an opponent at the same world. In RSW Core, D-Ships have the same firepower as ships on orbiting fleets. Specifically, each ship on a fleet gets one shot, and each D-Ship also gets one shot. It takes two shots to destroy each one of your opponent's ships.

Combat and movement occur simultaneously. If a fleet moves away while you fire at it, it only takes half damage.

You cannot simultaneously move and fire a fleet in the same turn.

You may fire an orbiting fleet at D-Ships. If you do this, and fire with at least two more shots than necessary to destroy all the D-Ships, the world will become neutral. The world will remain neutral--unowned by any player--until there is only one player remaining with ships at the world, according to the standard capture rules.

Ambush

Any ships you have at a world, whether they are D-Ships, or ships on fleets, that were not already moving or firing, will normally fire automatically at any enemy's fleets that move through the world without stopping (that is, fleets that move in multiple hops at once, enroute to a different world).

When ships fire in ambush mode, they do double damage: each D-Ship or fleet ship that ambush fires can destroy one unloaded ship.

As if that weren't enough, ambushing ships can fire at multiple different targets in the same turn--so if an enemy attempts to bring more than one fleet through your world without stopping, your D-Ships and fleets at that world will ambush fire at *each* of them, doing double damage to each enemy fleet.

There are some very important things to understand about ambush. First, it *only* applies when an enemy attempts to pass completely through a world enroute to another world, using multiple hops. That is, only the ships at the fleet's intermediate stops, if any, can ambush. The ships at a fleet's final destination will not ambush fire. (You do not have to be the owner of the world in order for your fleets to ambush fire at that world.)

Second, only those ships that did not not receive an explicit move or fire order will ambush fire. If you ordered a fleet to move, or if you ordered a fleet to fire at some target , then that fleet will not ambush that turn. Similarly, if you ordered your D-Ships to fire, then they will not ambush.

It is possible to turn off the auto-ambush feature at any particular world or worlds, or at all worlds you own, for a given turn. This is only very rarely done. You might do this, for instance, to extend

safe-passage to an opponent through a particular set of worlds.

The ambush rule helps you to defend your inner circle of worlds with D-Ships, forcing your enemies to approach slowly, one turn at a time, or risk being decimated by your ambush fire.

Miscellaneous Rules

These chapters describe some of the more esoteric or advanced rules of the game. If you are a beginner, it may not be important for you to understand these in detail, but you should plan to come back and read this section in detail as you gain a mastery of the game.

- Capturing Worlds and Fleets
- Order Codes

Capturing Worlds and Fleets

The rules for ownership of worlds and fleets are fundamentally simple: you will automatically capture any world or fleet when you are the only player with ships there.

That is to say, if you bring a fleet to a world, and there is no other player with fleets at that world, and there are no D-Ships on that world, then you will become the new owner of the world, as well as of any (empty) fleet keys at that world.

On the other hand, if two different players bring their fleets to a world at the same time, then ownership of the world does not change. If the world was previously owned by anyone, it will remain owned by that player. If the world was previously neutral, it will remain neutral. If there are any empty fleet keys at the world, they will become neutral (even if they were previously owned by a player).

Note that if you have any empty fleet keys at a world, you will lose ownership of them if another player brings a fleet there. At the best, they will become neutral; and at the worst, they will be owned by the newcomer. If you want to keep ownership of your fleet keys, it is best to keep at least one ship on each one.

Teammates

You can declare any player you meet in the game to be a *teammate.* This instructs the game not to perform ambush fire on a teammate passing through your worlds. This is *all* it means!

Note that declaring someone your teammate doesn't necessarily mean that you trust them or even that you intend to work with them. All it does is disable the automatic ambush fire against that player, until you declare them no longer a teammate.

The other player will *not* be told that you have declared them your teammate. Note that there's no reason to assume that the other player has also declared *you* a teammate!

In the RSW Classic game, there is a further distinction between allies and loaders. There is no such distinction in the Core game.

Order Codes

It is not necessary to memorize, or even to know, any of the following order codes if you use the RSW Client to play the game. However, if you are an advanced player, you may find it useful to know at least some of them; you can type any of these orders directly by pressing Control+Y in the game window.

If you use the web interface or the email interface to play RSW, you *must* use these order codes to enter your orders.

In the table below, lowercase sequences like *aa* or *bb* stand for a numeric fleet, world, or artifact index. The sequence *xx* stands for a count of ships, population, etc. (The use of doubled letters here is simply for readability; it does not imply the index numbers must be strictly two digits.)

For instance, the order F32T4F5, which is an example of the first of the transfer orders in the table, means to transfer 4 ships from fleet 32 to fleet 5. Note that each order must be entered as a single word, with no intervening punctuation or spaces between the parts of the order. Case is not important (you may enter the order in either uppercase or lowercase).

Note that the sequence in which you type your orders does not matter--the game will execute orders in a particular, predefined sequence, which has nothing to do with the order in which you typed them. In particular, transfer orders are always issued before movement and fire orders.

Ambush control	
Z	Turn off auto-ambush at all worlds (for one turn)
Z*aa*	Turn off auto-ambush at world *aa* (for one turn)
Alliances	
A=handle	Declare player "handle" your ally (teammate)
N=handle	Declare player "handle" is no longer your ally (teammate)

†Note: This order is optional. Fleets that have not been given any movement or fire orders will perform ambush fire whether or not you have issued the order F*aa*S. However, issuing this order can help make it easier for you to remember that you intended a particular fleet specifically to do nothing in a particular turn, as opposed to a fleet that you may have simply overlooked.

The RSW Classic and Advanced Game Types

The RSW Classic game is an homage to a classic play-by-mail game that debuted in the 1970's, known as Starweb (and which is still offered today by Flying Buffalo, Inc.). Whether you have experience playing this other game or not, the RSW Classic game is an exciting game, with moderately complex rules.

The RSW Advanced game builds further on the basic rules of the Classic game, adding additional character types and abilities. Furthermore, scoring is slightly adjusted in the Advanced game in an attempt to keep the game balanced.

The RSW Classic and Advanced game rules tend to favor alliances and partnerships over lone-wolf tacticians and pure military combat.

In the Classic game, each player will be one of six character types. The different character types will have different (sometimes competing) goals to satisfy in order to win the game.

- An Emperor is interested in conquering as much of the galaxy as possible. They gain points for owning many worlds and lots of industry.
- A Collector is only interested in collecting the various artifacts--special collectible objects--scattered throughout the galaxy. They gain points for each artifact held. Collectors can usually coexist peacefully with other players.
- A Raider gains points for plunder. Plundering a world makes it temporarily useless. A Raider must always be on the prowl for fresh worlds to plunder. A Raider can often make a strategic alliance with other players, but it can be tricky to work out the details.
- A Trader is interested in trade. A trader is usually welcome anywhere, since a trader gains points for delivering metal (valuable resources) to other players.
- A Positronix represents a race of robots dedicated to the extermination of all human life. They get points for killing humans in any context.
- A Missionary is a religious fanatic determined to spread their belief throughout the galaxy. A Missionary is often despised by the other character types (except Positronix), since the Missionary's converts spread through human populations like a virus, and can be difficult to eradicate. The Missionary gets points for making as many converts as possible.

The Advanced game type adds the following five character types as additional options:

- An Architect is a special race with a unique ability to bend space (and maps) to their wishes. An Architect can construct and destroy connections between worlds, though usually at great cost.
- An Arms Dealer is a mobile industrial platform. They can load raw metal from worlds and turn them into ships on demand, even in the absence of industry.
- A Skip Tracer is a master of spying and movement. Very little in the universe remains invisible to the Skip Tracer's eyes.
- A Scavenger is adept at stealing and repairing damaged ships. The Scavenger takes ships destroyed from their opponent and makes them their own!
- A Warlord is the fiercest military opponent of all. What a Warlord wants, they take. And what a Warlord sees, they want.

Select a topic below for more information:

- Quick Strategy Guide
- A Sample Walk-Through
- The Game Rules in Depth

Quick Strategy Guide: RSW Classic

There are three key resources you will need to acquire to succeed in RSW Classic:

- **Worlds.** You need to own a certain number of worlds to provide the raw metal to build ships, and also to provide a buffer to protect your homeworld from enemy invasions. You acquire an initial collection of worlds by being the first player to visit them in the first three or four turns of the game--this is why it is important to expand as quickly as possible, and reach as many worlds as possible before other players get there first.
- **Fleets.** There are only a fixed number of fleets in the game, and you have to acquire them, the same way you acquire worlds--that is, you have to be the first player to find them, before someone else gets to them first.

- **Ships.** Ships are military muscle. The more ships you can put on a fleet, the more powerful the fleet becomes. If you want to overwhelm your opponents with force, you will need lots of fleets, with lots of ships each. You build ships using the metal produced by your collection of worlds.

You begin every RSW game with one homeworld, five empty fleets, and enough metal to build 30 ships. The first turn is always pretty much the same--you should build those 30 ships onto your five fleets, distributing them however you see fit, and then send at least one fleet to each of the worlds connected to your homeworld.

Capturing Worlds and Fleets

On the second turn, you will have captured each of the worlds you sent a fleet to. Hopefully, you will also have captured a few more fleets--there are empty fleets scattered around throughout the galaxy. You probably won't have encountered another player yet, so your second turn is usually always the same too: transfer a few ships from your fleets to any new fleets you have captured, and then move fleets out to any new outlying worlds you can reach. Again, move at least one fleet to each world you can connect to, if at all possible--remember, you want to expand as quickly as possible, and claim as many worlds as you can reach, before someone else claims these worlds first.

Here we should pause a moment to point out a few important rules of the game:

- Ships can be transferred at will, fleet-to-fleet, fleet-to-world, or world-to-fleet.
- You need to have at least one ship on a fleet to keep and use the fleet.
- You need to have at least one ship on a world (as I-Ships or P-Ships) to keep the world.

You don't necessarily have to put a ship on each world that you come across, but if you don't, then the first player to visit the world in your absence will automatically capture it from you. Putting at least one I-Ship or P-Ship on every world will make it easier for you to hang on to your empire. Of course, you've only got so many ships to go around, so you do have to plan carefully.

This leads us to the next major strategy point of an RSW Classic game.

Hauling Metal

Consider these points:

- You need more ships. (You will always need more ships.)
- Your homeworld has 30 industry, which is enough to build 30 ships per turn, but it doesn't have much metal--it only produces 2 metal per turn.
- By the fourth turn, you will have captured several worlds, which collectively will produce at least 30 metal per turn.

It's time to start thinking about transporting metal from your outlying worlds back to your homeworld, so you can build lots of ships. Ideally, you want to bring at least 30 metal to your homeworld every turn, to fully utilize your industry.

- You can use some of your fleets to load metal at your outlying worlds and bring it to your homeworld.
- Usually, each fleet can carry up to one metal per ship.

Of course, you won't have enough ships yet to carry 30 metal--so do the best you can with the ships you have, until you have a chance to build more. Keep in mind that the first player to get their homeworld up to building a sustained 30 ships per turn may have a substantial military advantage over the other players.

And this, of course, brings us to the next, and most important part of the game:

Encountering Other Players

Usually you will meet your first opponent on the third or fourth turn. Sometimes you will encounter multiple opponents at once. These other players will be trying to expand their empire as quickly as possible, just as you are, and your presence has just marked the edge of their expansion. Possibly one of you has just inadvertently captured a world or fleet from the other, as a result of your surprise meeting.

Now it's up to you. You will have to negotiate with these other players to establish your borders, and the nature of your relationship. Will you establish a new international community of trust and friendship? Will you form an alliance with one neighbor to defeat a common enemy? Will you refuse to talk with anyone, and seek to immediately crush any player you encounter?

However you handle negotiations, keep in mind the need to dedicate some of your fleets to the task of carrying metal back to your homeworld. If you get distracted in little border skirmishes with the first neighbor you encounter, it may limit your ability to get your industry up to full production quickly--and a third player, who got there first, may suddenly sweep down and crush both of you.

Character Type

So far, we've been talking about things that are important to all players, such as acquiring worlds and building up your military might. But once you start negotiating with other players, it's also time to start thinking about your (and their) specific needs.

A complete description of each character type's needs are beyond the scope of this quick guide (they are discussed in detail elsewhere within this manual), but here are a few things to consider:

Emperors have the simplest needs, and may be the easiest to understand. They just want worlds. An Emperor is a particularly easy character type to play well, since it is possible for an Emperor to win the game without interacting with any other players at all--as long as you remain tucked away in your little corner of the galaxy with a sufficient collection of worlds, and other players leave you alone there, you'll accumulate a steady stream of points every turn. Of course, if other players decide to invade your empire, you'll have to be prepared to defend yourself. If this is your first experience with RSW, it may be a good idea to sign up as an Emperor, if it is available.

Raiders and Missionaries are the next step up from Emperors, in strategic complexity. Both of these have some unique special abilities, and they can be a lot of fun to play. In order to play these character types well, you will need to interact with (or conquer) your neighbors and develop a sound military and/or diplomatic strategy. However, these character types can also accumulate some points simply for owning resources and being left alone (though not as quickly as the Emperor does).

The next is the Positronix, the fierce metallic warriors of RSW. The Positronix is a very powerful fighter, but in order to score well as a Positronix, you will need to take a very active role in building

and using your military force. We recommend playing as a Positronix only if you are ready to demonstrate your mastery of military tactics.

The Collector is very simple to understand, but playing the Collector well can demand all of your diplomatic finesse. In order to collect enough artifacts to score well, a Collector must be able to gain the trust and assistance of many other players in the game (or, alternatively, to build up the military force necessary to dominate them all). This is often a challenge for beginning RSW players, but don't be afraid to give it a try!

Finally, a Trader is the best kind of character type to encounter early in the game. The Trader earns points by helping other players carry metal back to their homeworlds. A Trader will probably immediately offer to negotiate this kind of arrangement, and you should probably accept--since with a good Trader working for you, you will be in a good position to get your industry to full production before any other players, who don't have the similar help of a Trader--and thus you may reach a position of early military dominance. (But be sure you can trust your new Trader ally!) If you are a new RSW player, you may find playing a Trader to be a challenge for your first game. We recommend choosing one of the other character types instead.

A Sample Walk-Through: RSW Classic

In the following few pages, we'll illustrate playing the first few turns of a sample RSW Classic game.

There are two fundamentally different interfaces to use to play RSW: you can play it via the web interface, which presents a strictly text-based interface to the game, or via the downloadable RSW Client, which is graphical. We will illustrate the graphical client interface here.

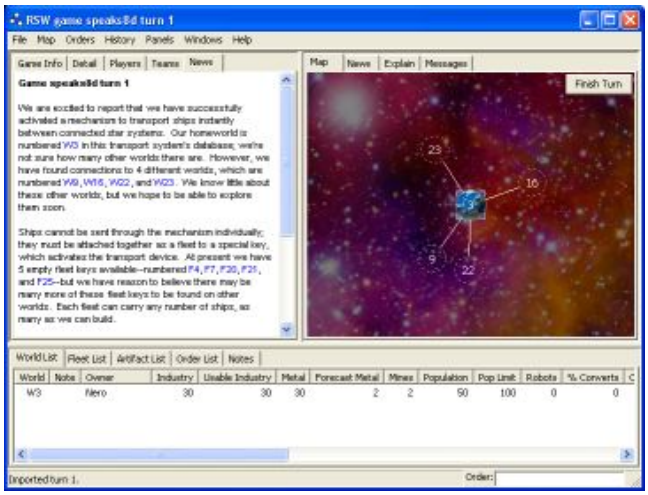
If this is your first time playing RSW, we recommend you download and use the RSW Client to play. The RSW Client provides a much friendlier user interface to the same game data; and is usually a much better choice for a beginner.

- The First Turn
- The Second Turn
- The Third Turn

The First Turn

Suppose you have signed up for an RSW Classic game, as an Emperor named Nero, and the game has just begun.

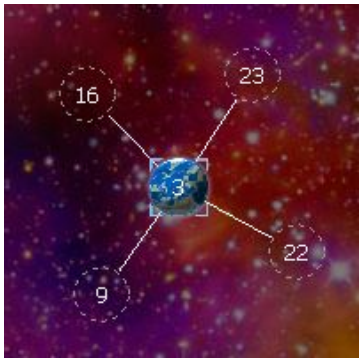
When you next start the RSW Client, the new game will automatically download into the client, and when you click on it, you'll see something like this:



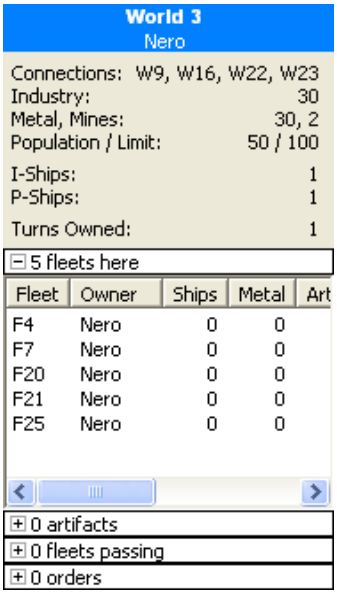
This is the Game Window, and this is where you will do most of your interaction with the game. The Game Window consists of three different panels, each of which contains several tabs across the top, allowing you to select between the various pages of information available for each panel.

Once you have read the Turn News panel in the center, you may want to switch to the upper-right panel to the Map view, which gives you more room to work with. Take a closer look at the map. The RSW Client has drawn your homeworld, world 3, on the map in color, and it shows four worlds connected to it, numbered 9, 16, 22, and 23.

These other worlds are the worlds that you can reach directly from your homeworld. The RSW Client doesn't really know what order or placement to use for these worlds; it's just a shot in the dark, and you might need to move them around later, as you discover more connections to other worlds. (Though note that in some RSW games, depending on the game settings, the worlds might be placed automatically in their correct position, and you don't have to move them around yourself.) For now, click and drag the worlds around to any configuration that pleases you, giving plenty of space for filling in the new worlds you'll discover later, something like this:



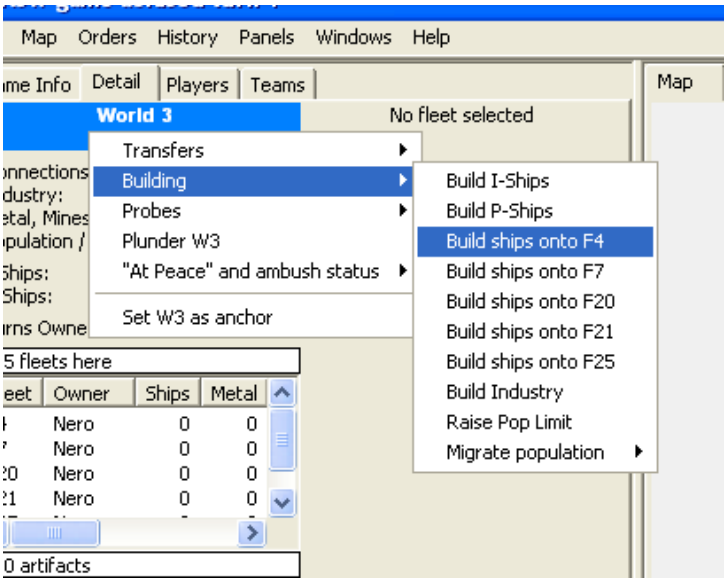
Now click on the "Detail" tab on the upper-right panel, to bring the Detail panel to the foreground, and then click on the colored world in the map representing your homeworld, to select your homeworld, world 3. You will see the following display in the detail panel:



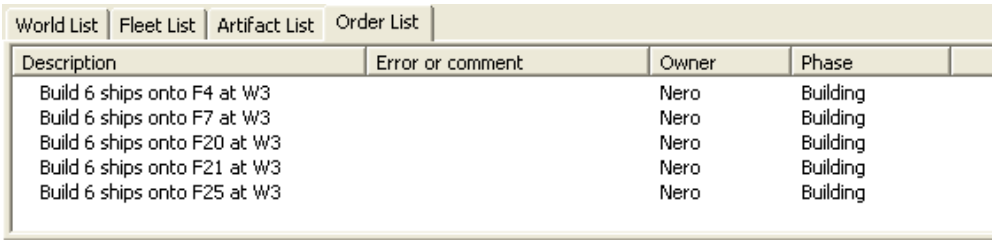
As you can see, your homeworld has 30 industry, 30 metal, 2 mines, and 50 population, with a population limit of 100. Furthermore, you have 1 I-Ship and 1 P-Ship, and the "turns owned" counter is 1.

You can also see the five fleets you have. You always start each game with a random set of five empty fleets. In this example, you have fleets 4, 7, 20, 21, and 25; and as expected, each of them has 0 ships.

On your first turn, you should almost always build up your 30 ships onto your fleets, and then send your fleets to visit the connected worlds. We'll issue the orders to do that now. Right-click (or, on a Mac, control-click) on the World title to pop up the orders menu, and select "Build ships onto F4," like this:

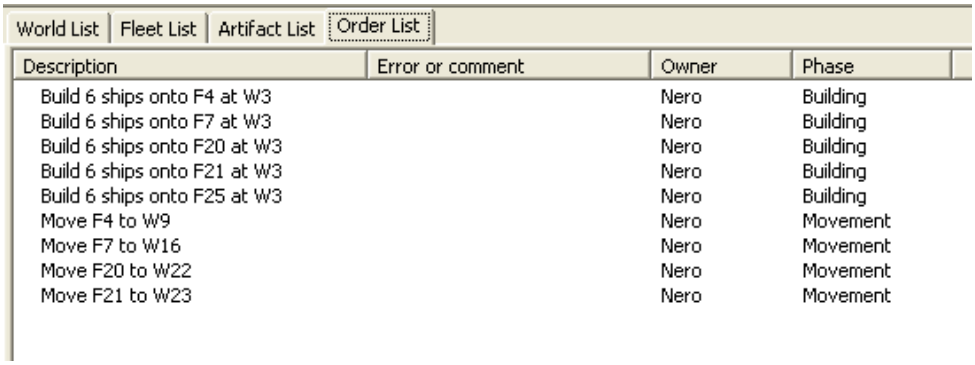


When prompted, enter that you want to build 6 ships, and then do the same thing for the other four fleets. Congratulations! You have entered the five build orders. If you were to click on the Orders tab in the bottom panel, you would see those orders, like this:



Now that we've built 6 ships onto each of our fleets, let's order them to explore the connected worlds. Once again, right-click (or control-click) on the World title, and this time select "Move F4 to W9", and then do it again for each of the other fleets, picking a different world for each one. We'll arbitrarily send fleet 4 to world 9, fleet 7 to world 16, fleet 20 to world 22, and fleet 21 to world 23. That leaves fleet 25 still sitting at home, but we don't have a fifth world to visit, so it can just wait till next turn.

The order list now looks like this:



Congratulations! You have entered the orders for your first turn.

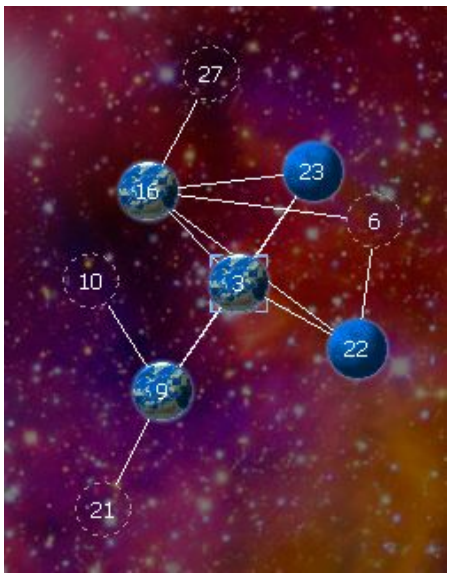
It's often a good idea to double-check that you have entered the orders you think you have. One easy way to do this is to select "Project turn 2" from the History menu. This will switch the game view to a hypothetical turn 2, to show you what would happen when all of your orders are performed. It can't show you what will definitely happen on turn 2, because it doesn't know what orders the other players may enter, and it doesn't know anything about the worlds you haven't visited yet, but it will give you a good idea of what you have ordered your fleets and worlds to do, at least.

While you are in this project-next-turn view, click on each of the worlds, and confirm that they now have one of your fleets visiting them, and that each fleet has 6 ships. If all is as you expect, then pick "View turn 1" from the History menu to go back to the normal, current turn's view.

There's still one more, very important step to be done. You need to submit your orders to the server, or they won't count. Click the "Finish Turn" button on the map, click OK to accept the confirmation dialog, and then sit back and wait for the other players to submit their orders too.

The Second Turn

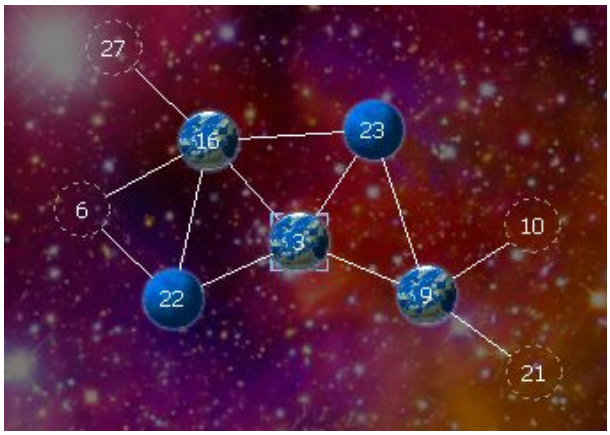
When all the other players in the game have entered their orders and the first turn runs, the RSW Client will automatically download the second turn. When you launch the Game Window, now, the first thing you will notice is that your map is no longer quite so neat and tidy:



Remember, last turn, you moved a fleet to each of the four worlds your homeworld connects to (and, in doing so, you captured those four worlds, so you own them now--note that they're now drawn in the same color as your homeworld, to represent this). Your fleets have sent back a complete report on those four worlds, including the worlds they connect to, and so the RSW Client has automatically integrated that data on the map (and in this particular sample game, the worlds are not positioned automatically for you).

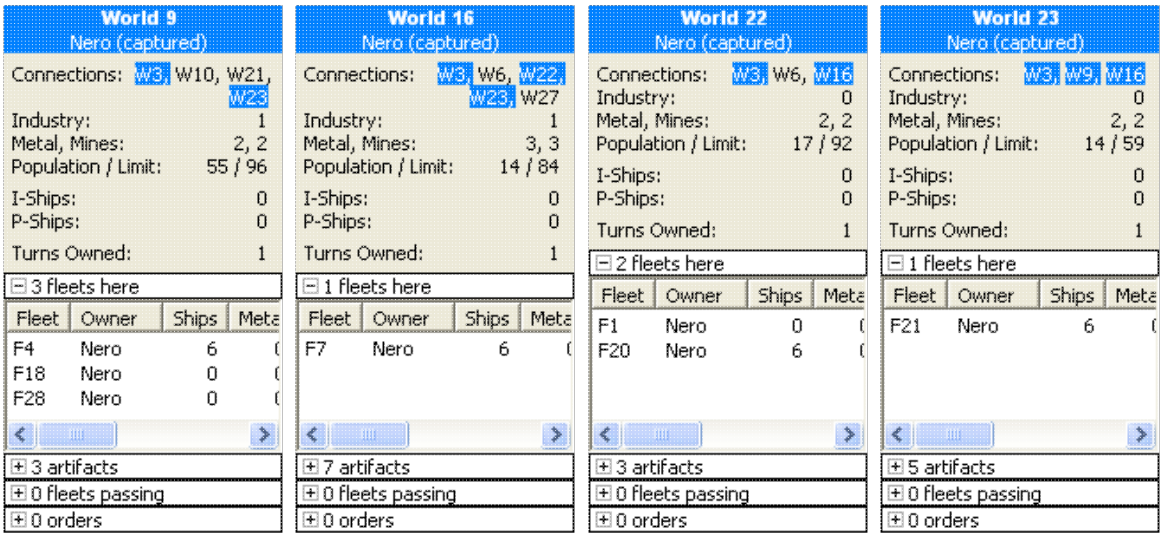
The RSW Client won't reposition any of the worlds that were already on the map, and now the new connections make it apparent that our original guesswork wasn't correct. For instance, since world 16 and world 22 both connect to each other (and also since they both connect to world 6), they should probably appear next to each other on the map.

Click and drag the worlds around to straighten out the map. You should be able to find a placement for all the worlds that requires a minimal crossing of the lines that connect them. When you're done fixing the map, you may have something that looks more like this:



Now you can study what you've learned about the various worlds. Once again, bring up the Detail panel in the upper-left panel, and click on each new world, one a time, to read about the properties of each world.

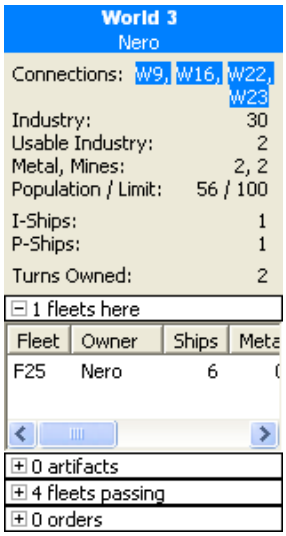
(Note that there are also other ways to study the world properties, rather than click on them one at a time. For instance, you can use the world list in the bottom panel to get an overview of all worlds at once. There are also options in the Preferences menu to display some world properties visually in the map display. For now, though, we'll just use the Detail panel.)



That fact that your name--Nero--is written in the world title for each new world is confirmation that you are the new owner of each of these worlds. Now take a moment to read the metal, mines, population, and population limit of each world. You can also see that there are a number of artifacts at each world; if you wanted to see more about that, you would click on the line that says "3 artifacts" (or whatever number) to expand the list of artifacts.

Now note that, in addition to the four new worlds, you have also acquired three new fleets in your name: F18 and F28 are at W9, and F1 is at W22. You can--and probably should--immediately transfer some of your ships over to these new fleets, and put these fleets into active service.

Let's also take a moment to see what's going on at your homeworld:



There's a new line displayed here: "Usable Industry: 2". This means that although you have 30 industry, only two of it is ready to build this turn. The reasons that some of your industry cannot build will vary, but in this case it is because you only have two metal this turn. (This is the metal that was produced by your two mines last turn.) If you ever have any question about why all of your industry isn't available to build, or some similar question, you can click on the Explain tab, which will explain the reasons for each current limitation at the selected world.

Now that we've studied the current situation, we're ready to input some orders. We need to send at least one fleet to each new world, to continue expanding as quickly as possible; so we'll start by sending fleet 7 to world 27. From world 9 we now have two new fleets, numbered 18 and 28, so we'll send these to worlds 10 and 21, respectively. (We have to transfer some ships to these fleets before we can use them, so we'll divide the six ships on fleet 4 three ways, and put two ships on each of fleet 18 and fleet 28.)

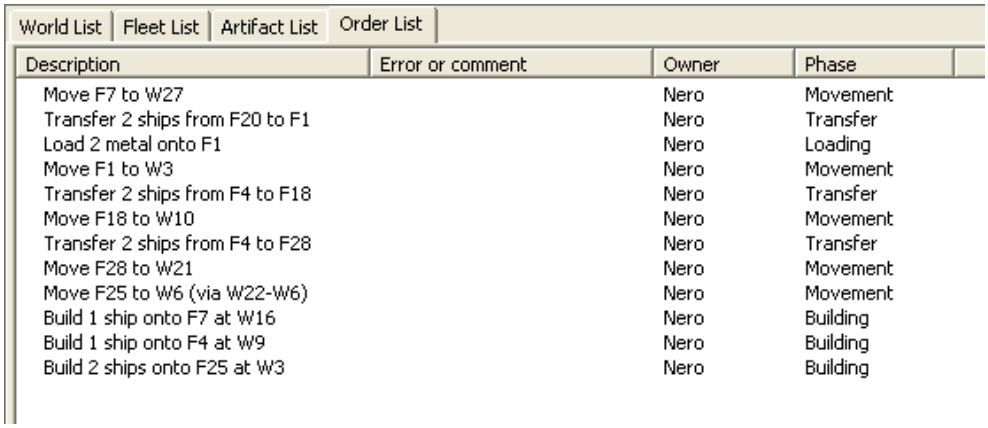
That just leaves world 6. We still have fleet 25 sitting at our homeworld, unused since the first turn, so we'll send that one over to world 6. We'll order this fleet to move through world 22 to arrive at world 6--a fleet can move through up to two worlds like this, to arrive at a third world in one turn.

Finally, at world 22 we have a couple of fleets that aren't being used for anything, so we might as well use one of them to bring a bit of metal back to our homeworld--every little bit helps. There are only two units of metal to bring back, so we only need two ships to carry it--so we'll order fleet 20 to transfer two ships to fleet 1, and then order fleet 1 to load up the metal there and then send the fleet back to our homeworld.

We're doing quite a bit all in one turn with fleet 1--we transfer two ships to it, load two metal onto it, and move it to our homeworld. This all works, because according to the game rules, transfers happen before loading metal, which happens before movement. This is always true, regardless of the sequence in which we added these orders. (Even if we had ordered the fleet to move to our homeworld first, and then ordered it to load metal, it would load metal first, from world 22, and then move to our homeworld.)

Now the only thing that we haven't done is give any orders to industry. There is one unit of industry on world 16 and another one on world 9, plus the industry we have on our homeworld. Let's take advantage of this industry to build ships onto our fleets, so we'll order world 9 to build one ship onto fleet 4, and order world 16 to build one ship onto fleet 7. At world 3, our homeworld, we'll build two ships onto fleet 25. Note that building, like loading, takes place before movement, so we can build onto these fleets even though we've already given each of them orders to move to a different world.

Use right-click (or control-click, on a Mac) on each relevant world, to enter each of these orders. The order list now looks like this:



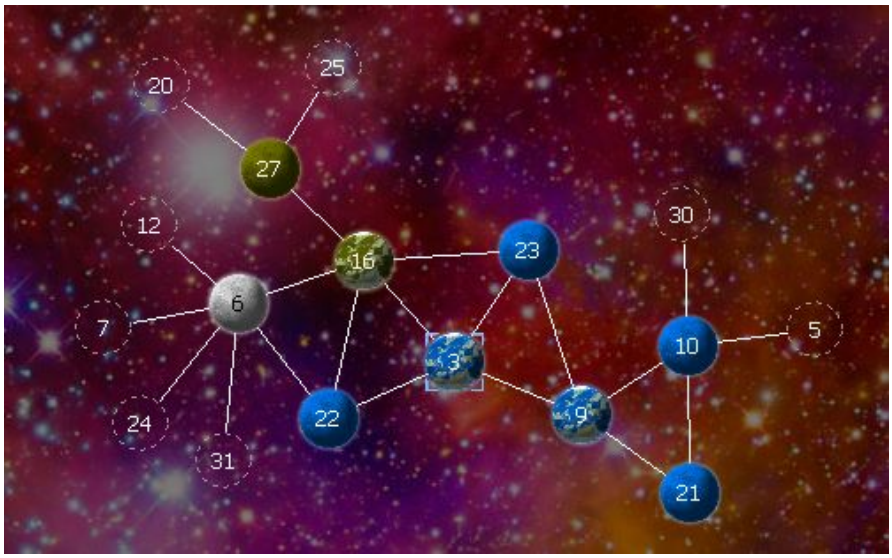
If you have any doubts about the sequence in which the orders will be executed, you can click on the last column, which will group the orders into their execution phases, and then sort those phases into the order in which they will be executed.

Now, just as we did with the first turn, it's useful to project the next turn as a sanity check, before submitting the orders. Pick "Project turn 3" from the History menu, and examine the resulting sitatuation. Make sure that your fleets ended up at the worlds you expected them to.

Once you're happy with the new orders, go back to viewing turn 2, click the "Finish Turn" button, and click OK to send them to the server.

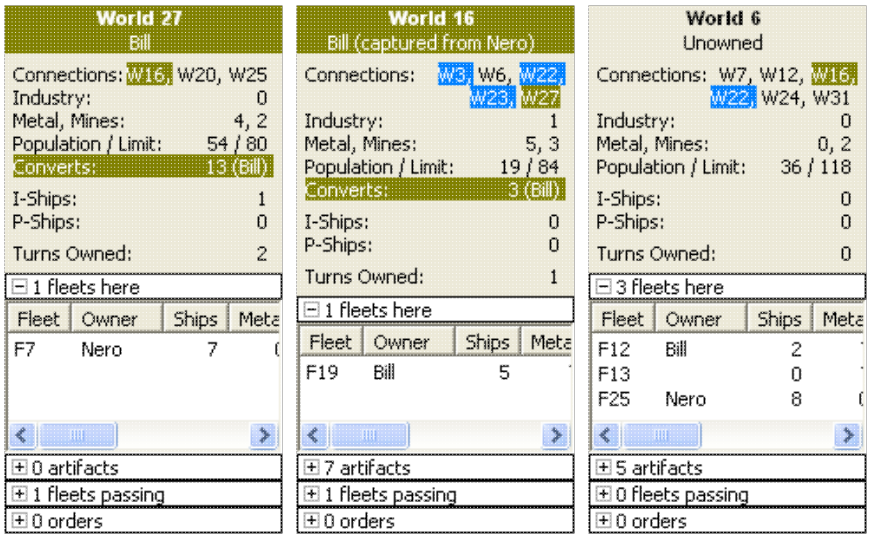
The Third Turn

Once the third turn begins, and after you straighten out the new map connections, you have a map something like this:



Now, this is getting interesting! You have encountered another player! The RSW Client has picked a random color to assign to the new player, which happens to be brown in this case.

Let's take a closer look at the worlds on which you have encountered this new player:



So, what happened? It looks like fleet 7, which we'd ordered to world 27 last turn, arrived there as ordered, and found the world was already owned by the new player, Bill. At the same time, fleet 19--one of Bill's fleets--arrived on your world 16, and captured it from you! (If you click on fleet 19 in the list, you'll see that it was moved from world 27 to world 16 this turn.)

Why did Bill's fleet capture world 16 from you, yet your fleet did not capture world 27 from Bill? The difference is the I-Ships. Bill has left 1 I-Ship on world 27--you can see this I-Ship listed in the Detail panel for world 27, above--which prevents your fleet from automatically capturing the world from them. On the other hand, you have left no ships on world 16, so when Bill's fleet arrived, they were the only player with ships at that world, and so they automatically captured it from you.

You could, of course, now order fleet 7 to fire at Bill's one I-Ship on world 27. That would destroy the I-Ship, and presuming Bill does not send any reinforcements to the world, you would then capture the world from them. But that sort of aggressive act would be sure to put a strain on any diplomatic relationships with your nearest neighbor. Remember, Bill didn't necessarily intend to capture world 16 from you, and chances are good that they will be willing to return ownership of world 16 to you, maybe as part of some broader agreement--but you'll have to work that out with Bill.

Now, world 6 is also interesting. No one owns this world, because both you and Bill arrived there at the same time. As long as both of you have ships there, neither one will capture it, but if one of you moves your fleet away this turn and the other remains, then the one player remaining will capture the world. In general, you capture a world by being the only player with ships there (including I-Ships and P-Ships). Any negotiations with Bill will certainly involve a discussion of the future ownership of world 6.

Note the empty, unowned fleet 13 at world 6. Like the world itself, this fleet is unowned, until there is only one player there with ships there--and that player will then own this fleet. Before that time, you should not attempt to transfer ships to this unowned fleet, since doing so will not capture the fleet; it would only give away the ships.

There's one more thing worth pointing out here: Bill has left a trail of converts behind. There are 13 converts on world 27 (out of 54 total population, or 24%), and 3 now on world 16 (out of 19 population, or 16%). This tells you immediately that Bill must be a Missionary. Many of the other character types are not so immediately recognizable, but knowing that Bill is a Missionary will help you know what concessions they will ask of you (for instance, maybe they will be willing to let you keep world 6, in return for letting them make converts there).

In any case, the real game of RSW has just begun. From now on, everything you do will be colored by your diplomatic success or failure with Bill, as well as with any other neighbors you encounter in the future. You should click on the Messages tab in the game window to send an introductory message to Bill to get things going.

Good luck!

The Game Rules in Depth: RSW Classic

The rules for playing RSW Classic are moderately complex. We recommend you skim through these chapters first to get an overall feel for the game, then come back when you need to consult some particular section in more detail.

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Worlds

The galaxy consists of a number of worlds, most of which are initially unowned by any player. The precise number of worlds varies per game (and is loosely based on the number of players); in any particular game, there may be dozens of worlds, or there may be hundreds.

Most worlds are connected to two, three, or four other worlds. Some worlds might have only one connection; some may have as many as five or six. Ultimately, all worlds are interconnected in a single contiguous Web.

Almost all worlds are inhabitable, and in fact already have a thriving population. This is good because you cannot own a world that has no population living on it. Most worlds also produce a certain amount of metal each turn, which are important resources to keep your industry churning. A few worlds may also have a few units of industry, but for the most part you will need to rely on the industry at your homeworld.

As you visit new, unowned worlds in the galaxy, you will automatically plant your flag on them, so to speak, and claim them as your own. The exact rules of ownership are a little more complex, but in general, you will own any world that you are the first to visit.

- Population
- Industry and Building
- Mines
- The "Turns Owned" Number
- Metal
- I-Ships and P-Ships
- Plundering
- Probes
- Black Holes

Population

The population of a world is necessary to work its mines, run its industry, manage its planetary defense--and feel a sense of national pride. You cannot own a world that has 0 population.

Normally, a world's population will grow by about 10% every turn, up to its population limit, and then stop growing. The population on an unowned world will not grow; neither will the population on a world that is still recovering from a recent plunder. A robotic population will not grow by itself, but must be built. If the world is owned by an Missionary, then all of the new population each turn will be converts.

- Converts
- Robots

Converts

If you have converts at a world, then you know an Missionary has been at work. Whenever a Missionary visits a world, there is a certain chance that they will convert some of the population to their religion. (Specifically, each ship that the Missionary brings to a world, on a fleet not At Peace,, has a 10% chance of converting one population.)

Once converts are established on a world, they will continue to grow, by about 10% each turn. (Each convert has a 10% chance of converting another population, each turn.) If the converts ever reach 100% of the population, then the Missionary will automatically capture the world. And even before then, the converts act as spies: the Missionary that owns the converts will get a full report on the activities at any world with even one convert.

You can attempt to eliminate converts by unloading consumer goods at the world (or invite a Trader ally to do it for you). Each consumer good unloaded has a 50% chance of unconverting one convert, so if you have a lot of converts, this can get expensive.

You can also fire at converts, killing them. This is much more efficient then buying them back, but it has a cost too. Firstly, unless you are a Positronix (or another Missionary pronouncing Judgment), you will lose points for killing innocent civilians. Secondly, if the Missionary in question has not yet pronounced Judgment, then you will also be making their converts into martyrs, awarding them additional points. Finally, unless you have a substantial non-convert population, you may not have enough population left after killing the converts to work your industry or mines (converts are good workers).

Finally, you can try to get rid of converts simply by migrating them to a neighboring world. Of course, this will just put more converts at the neighboring world.

Only one Missionary at a time can own the converts at a given world. If a second Missionary attempts to make converts at a world, all of the converts will be owned by either one Missionary or the other (determined by random chance, and weighted on the relative number of converts for each Missionary).

In the RSW Client, the number of converts of a population, and the owner of the converts, are indicated on the World Detail panel. This information also appears on the text-based turn report accessible from the web page.

Robots

If you come across a world with a robotic population, you will know its owner is a Positronix: only a Positronix can control robots.

A Positronix's robots are efficient killing machines. If a Positronix drops robots on a world, they will immediately start killing humans (and vice-versa), at the rate of four humans to one robot. If there are still robots standing when the dust settles, then the world will have a robotic population.

Robotic populations do not grow automatically like humans populations do; robots must be built via industry. On the other hand, robots care nothing for population limits. And robots are just as efficient at working factories and mines as their human counterparts.

Robots, of course, are not interested in religion, and will not become converts.

In the RSW Client, if the population is robotic it will be indicated on the World Detail panel. In the text-based turn report, a robotic population is indicated with the suffix `R` following the population count, e.g. `Population=16R` indicates the population consists of 16 robots.

Industry

You start out the game with 30 industry (Classic game) or 40 (Advanced game) on your homeworld. Occasionally, you will come across another world that has 1 or 2 units of industry, but most worlds you discover will have no industry.

Industry is required to build ships. Since ships are the military muscle of the game, this is what your industry is likely to spend most of its time building. However, industry can also be used to build more industry, raise the population limit of a world, or migrate population to a neighboring world. A Positronix can also use industry to build robots.

In order to build with the industry on a world, you must first own the world. Also, you must have enough metal on that world to provide the raw materials to build with, and there must be enough population to work the factories. To put it precisely, your usable industry is the smallest of your industry, metal, and population.

When you build with industry, of course, the metal you use is consumed, and must be replenished to build more on subsequent turns. Note that you cannot unload metal and build with it in the same turn; the metal that you unload on a world cannot be used for building until next turn.

If there are enemy fleets at your world, your population may be reluctant to build--they will be hiding in bomb shelters. Specifically, for each enemy ship at a world that outnumbers your own ships and your ally's ships, one industry will not build. For this purpose, and this purpose only, I-Ships count double: their presence in defense of industry is particularly reassuring to your home population. P-Ships count only once, and fleets declared At Peace don't count at all.

Also, a world that is still recovering from a recent plunder will not be able to build.

If your world meets the requirements for its industry to build, it will *always* build; you can't order it not to. You can't prevent it from building by loading the metal onto a fleet (it will build with the metal before you can load it). If you don't give your industry any particular orders, it will build I-Ships.

- Building Ships
- Building Industry
- Raising the Population Limit
- Migration
- Building Robots
- Scrapping I-Ships to Make Industry

Building Ships

The most common thing to build with your industry is ships. You can choose to build I-Ships or P-Ships, or you can build ships onto any of the fleets at the world.

It costs one metal to build each ship.

If you are building ships onto fleets, be sure that you already own the fleet key before building onto it. If someone else owns the fleet, or the fleet key is unowned, you will be giving away the ships.

Building Industry

If you need more industry at a particular world, you can build more, but this is fairly expensive. It costs 5 metal to build each new unit of industry (unless you are an Emperor, in which case it only costs 4 metal).

Note that this means you must already have at least 5 industry (or 4 industry, if you're an Emperor) at a world before you can build more industry. If you don't have this much industry to start with, the only way to make more industry at a world is by scrapping I-Ships.

Raising the Population Limit

Occasionally, you will come across a world with a very low population limit. If you need to raise the population limit at a world, you can use your industry to do this, at the cost of 5 metal for each one unit increase to your population limit.

Robots, of course, are not concerned about population limits.

If your world's population is less than 5 to start with, then it cannot support the minimum population necessary to work the industry to raise the population limit. In this case, you will have to migrate more population to this world from a neighboring world. If you migrate more people than the population limit will support, they will die at the end of the turn; but before they die, they can work the industry for one round. This is an expensive way to raise the population limit, but unless you are a Positronix, it is the only way.

Migration

It is possible to move population from one world to a neighboring world, without the use of any ships or fleets. This is called migration.

Migrating population requires industry at the starting world, and consumes one metal for each population moved. The destination world must be directly connected to the starting world.

If you migrate humans to a robotic world, the humans and robots will kill each other off at the standard rate of four humans to one robot. The same thing will happen if a Positronix migrates robots from a robotic world to a human world (but if the Positronix kills off all the humans in this way, leaving at least one robot, they automatically capture the world).

If there are converts at the starting world and you migrate population, you will migrate only the ordinary population, leaving the converts behind. On the other hand, you can also specifically migrate the converts. In this case, the converts will move to the new world, leaving ordinary population behind. An Missionary may choose to do this to help spread their converts around; or another player may choose to use this technique to try to get *rid* of some of the converts at their world.

If you exceed the population limit at the destination world, the new population will die at the end of the next turn (but they will have an opportunity to build before they die).

You cannot migrate population simultaneously to more than one destination world from a given starting world in the same turn.

Building Robots

A Positronix may choose to use their industry to build robots, if the world's population is already robotic. This is the usual way for the Positronix to increase the population (robots do not automatically reproduce). It is not possible to build robots unless the population is already robotic; humans will refuse to operate the machinery.

Each one metal will produce two robots.

Scrapping I-Ships to Make Industry

If you need to build industry at a world and do not have enough industry already there to start with, you can choose to scrap I-Ships to make industry.

It takes 6 I-Ships to produce one industry, unless you are an Emperor, in which case it takes only 4 I-Ships to produce one industry.

The I-Ships must already be at the world at the start of the turn (you can't transfer them to I-Ships in the same turn you scrap them).

Mines

A world's mines will produce a certain amount of metal each turn--one metal per turn produced by each mine.

This requires having sufficient population to work the mines. If there is not enough population to work both the mines and the industry at a given world, the population will work the industry if there is enough metal already stockpiled to build with, and any remaining population will work the mines.

A world still recovering from a recent plunder will not produce anything from its mines.

Turns Owned

Each world has a "turns owned" counter. When you (or any player) capture a world, the "turns owned" number is set to 1. Each turn that you continue to own the world, the counter increases by 1, until it reaches 7; and then it resets to 1, restarting the process.

When the "turns owned" counter resets in this way, after the 7th turn without a change of ownership, if the number of mines at the world is at least 1 to start with, then the mines will increase by 1.

While a world is recovering from a plunder, its "turns owned" counter does not increase.

Metal

Metal is the basic fuel that drives your industry. You will need lots of metal to build the armada of ships that you will need to conquer the galaxy.

Metal is produced by a world's mines. Since usually the metal is produced on worlds that don't have a lot of industry, you must load metal from outlying worlds onto your fleets, and then carry it back to your homeworld, so you can make use of it to build more ships.

Usually, there will be enough metal produced collectively by the worlds within easy reach of your homeworld to keep your industry working at its full capacity of 30 units per turn--but you will have to organize your fleets enough to be able to dedicate enough ships to the task of picking up all this metal and bringing it back to your homeworld each turn.

If you are lucky enough to meet a Trader early in the game, you may find them willing to do the work of bringing your own metal back to your homeworld. The Trader has an advantage in this, since they can do the same job with half the number of ships that anyone else can; and this is also the primary way a Trader earns points. For this reason, a player who enlists the help of a Trader may be able to build up their ships--and thus, their military power--more quickly than other players who have to haul their own metal. (But keep an eye on your Trader ally's score, so you can decide on a propitious time to end the alliance!)

I-Ships and P-Ships

When you leave ships on the surface of a world, they can either be placed in defense of industry (I-Ships) or population (P-Ships). Collectively, these planetside ships are known as "Home Fleets".

The ships on Home Fleets are the same ships that you can attach to fleet keys and send off to explore the galaxy. You can transfer ships freely between I-Ships, P-Ships, and any fleets at a world.

Leaving ships behind as I-Ships or P-Ships has several strategic advantages. First, these ships can defend your ownership of the world, without having to dedicate a valuable fleet key to that task. Another player who shows up at the world will have to take a turn to destroy your home fleets before they can capture the world from you.

Second, I-Ships and P-Ships can fire back at any enemy fleets, although they only fire at half the strength of ships on fleets. Each two I-Ships or P-Ships fires one shot, unlike a regular fleet, in which each ship fires one shot.

There are also some special functions for I-Ships and P-Ships. I-Ships can be scrapped to build industry, and both I-Ships and P-Ships can fire at converts.

Finally, home fleets are critical to defend your inner circle of worlds via ambush. If an enemy tries to send a fleet through one or more of your worlds *without stopping,* then your home fleets can automatically fire at the fleets as they pass by--and in this capacity, the home fleets fire the same strength as orbiting fleets, which for ambush is double strength--two shots from each ship--and they can fire repeatedly at *each* fleet that passes through.

Plundering

Any player can plunder any world that they own, although usually it is only the Raiders who will want to. (This is because any player other than a Raider will lose 5 points for the act. But sometimes it's worth it anyway, for instance to deprive an enemy of the benefits of a world.)

In order to plunder a world successfully, you must own the world at the beginning of the turn, and still own the world at the end of the turn--you cannot plunder a world in the same turn that you capture it from someone else, or in the same turn that someone captures the world from you.

Plundering a world drives its economy into chaos and renders it nonproductive for the next three turns (only two turns in an Advanced game). While the world is recovering from the plunder, its mines will not produce any metal, its industry will not build, and its population will not grow. Even the turns owned counter will not increase.

You cannot plunder a world while it is still recovering from a previous plunder.

In the RSW Client, the number of times a world has been plundered, and the number of turns remaining to recover from a recent plunder are clearly indicated on the World Detail panel. On the text-based turn report, both numbers are indicated with a string like `Plunder=2/3` to indicate that a world has been plundered twice, and currently requires 3 turns to recover from a recent plunder.

Probes

Normally you will be told each turn about the worlds that you own, or at which you have fleets (or converts, if you are an Missionary.) Usually, the best way to find out current information about a world is to send a fleet there.

But it's also possible to get intelligence about a world without sending a fleet there. You can do this by sending a probe from a neighboring world.

A probe is a one-time ship you send through a connection without a fleet key. The ship is destroyed in transit, but it can send back an information report before it burns up.

Thus, each probe operation costs one ship, and can only be used to learn about worlds that are adjacent to worlds where you have a ship.

You can send an I-Ship or P-Ship as the source of your probe, or a ship on a fleet.

Black Holes

A very small percentage of the worlds in the galaxy will be *black holes.* If you are so unfortunate as to send a fleet to a black hole, or attempt to move through a black hole to another world, all of the ships on the fleet, and any metal it was carrying, will be immediately destroyed. The empty fleet key, being indestructible, will reappear on some other world at random. Any artifacts the fleet was carrying will similarly be scattered randomly throughout the galaxy.

If you probe a world, you will learn whether or not it is a black hole.

You should be aware of the danger of black holes, but do not be overly paranoid. Usually it is better to send fleets boldly into the unknown, and take the chance that you might be sending them into a black hole, then to spend the extra turn required to probe each unknown world first.

Your homeworld will never be directly adjacent to a black hole.

Fleets

A fleet key is necessary to send ships through a connection to another world. You can attach as many ships to a fleet key as you like; these ships then move and fire as a unit.

Ships can be built and destroyed, but the fleet key is indestructible. In general, we use the word "fleet" throughout the game to refer to a fleet key and all of its ships, even when there are no ships at all on the key.

In addition to the five fleet keys that you own at the beginning of the game, there are several more empty, unowned fleet keys scattered throughout the galaxy. The total number of fleets is fixed in a particular game (fleet keys cannot be created or destroyed), and the exact number depends on the number of players.

As with worlds, though the precise rules of ownership are more complex, in general, you will automatically claim as your own any empty fleet keys you find at the worlds you are the first to visit.

- Ships
- Transfers
- Movement
- Loading and Unloading Metal
- Commandeering
- At Peace

Ships

Ships define the capacity and strength of your fleets. You can build ships with your industry and metal. You must have at least one ship on each fleet key in order to keep ownership of it, but there is no upper limit to the number of ships you may put on any one fleet.

The ships define carrying capacity: each ship can carry one unit of metal (unless you are a Trader, in which case each ship can carry two units of metal).

The ships also define military power: each ship on a fleet can fire one shot at your enemies, and it takes two shots to destroy each enemy ship. Thus, the more ships you have, the more firepower you have; and the more firepower it will take to destroy your fleet.

Ships are not permanently associated with fleets--you can transfer ships back and forth between fleets, I-Ships, and P-Ships at will.

Transfers

You can freely move ships around between I-Ships, P-Ships, and all the fleets that are present at a

world at the beginning of a turn. This is called a transfer.

Transfers take place after unloading metal, and before loading more metal. If you transfer ships that are carrying metal without unloading the metal first, the metal will not transfer and may be lost.

Transferring ships to a fleet does not capture the fleet. Instead, transferring ships to a fleet you don't own will just give the ships away. Sometimes you want to do this (for instance, to give ships to an ally). If you transfer ships to an unowned, empty fleet key, you will create a neutral fleet, which is almost always a mistake.

Movement

Fleets may move to any directly connected world, or simultaneously through two or three consecutive connections. For example, if F13 is at W36, which has a connection to W25; and W25 has a connection to W2, and W2 has a connection to W10, then F13 can move in one turn through W25 and W2 to end up at W10.

When you move a fleet through multiple connections at once like this, you will get a complete report of any worlds you pass completely through, as well as the world you left and the world you arrived at. However, you may be vulnerable to ambush at either of the intervening worlds, if your opponents have any ships sitting idle at those worlds. Normally, you will move multiple hops like this only through your own worlds or through your allies' worlds, where you can be confident there will not be hidden enemies lurking.

You cannot both move and fire a fleet in the same turn.

Fleet movement takes place after transfers and loading and unloading, and at the same time as combat.

Loading and Unloading Metal

You can use your fleets to load metal from an outlying world, then transport it to another world (for instance, your homeworld), and unload it there, where it can be used by your industry to build.

Each ship can carry one unit of metal, unless you are a Trader, in which case each ship can carry two units of metal. (However, a Trader ship that is carrying two units of metal cannot fire.)

Loading and unloading take place before movement, so you can load metal from a world and move your fleet away from that world in the same turn--the metal will be loaded from the world at which the fleet started. When your fleet arrives at its destination, you can unload metal onto that world and move the fleet away in the same turn--again, the metal will be unloaded onto the world from which the fleet started. (You cannot, however, build with the metal you unload until the next turn.)

If your fleets are fired upon while they are carrying metal, the ships that are loaded will receive double damage. (Shots will hit unloaded ships before they hit loaded ships.) For this reason, you may want to unload or jettison your metal if you suddenly find your fleets in a hostile situation.

Normally, you will load metal from your own worlds. You can also load metal from your allies' worlds, if they have declared you to be a loader. For instance, it is particularly useful to declare a Trader ally to be a loader for you, since a Trader can load and carry your metal more efficiently than

you can.

You can see how much metal your own fleets are carrying, but you cannot see how much metal, if any, other players' fleets are carrying.

- Unloading Consumer Goods
- Jettisoning Metal

Unloading Consumer Goods

It is possible to transform raw metal into "consumer goods"--things like cell phones and flat-panel televisions--as you unload the metal onto a world.

The "consumer goods" unloaded in this way disappear--they are snapped up by an eager population. It is no longer metal, and cannot be used again. The main reason to do this is to attempt to win back converts, those unfortunate members of your population who have fallen under the influence of an enemy Missionary.

Each consumer good unloaded has a 50% chance of un-converting one convert, so it is most practical to use this technique while there are still relatively few converts at a world.

If you are a Trader, you also gain points for unloading consumer goods, whether or not there are converts at a world.

Jettisoning metal

Occasionally, you may find yourself in a situation where your fleets are carrying more metal than you'd like them to be carrying. For instance, if you are a Trader, and you are taking advantage of your special ability to haul two units of metal for each ship, your overloaded ships cannot fire. Even if you are not a Trader (or your ships are not overloaded), you may not want to be carrying metal in a hostile situation, since loaded ships will receive twice as much damage as unloaded ships when fired upon.

If you are at a friendly world, you can simply unload the metal on the spot (unloading happens before combat). But if you happen to be at an opponent's world and you'd rather not give the metal to your opponent, then you may have no choice but to jettison the metal, which destroys the metal for good.

Commandeer

Generally, as long as you have at least one ship on your fleets, the fleet cannot be taken from you. There is, however, one exception: the Raider's Commandeer attack!

If you encounter a Raider at a world, and their ships on fleets outnumber your ships on fleets by more than three to one, the Raider will automatically capture all of your fleets, along with all of the ships, artifacts, and metal on them. The Raider calls this *Commandeering* your fleets.

This special capture happens at the end of the round, after all normal combat.

If there are multiple players with fleets at a world, the Raider must outnumber all of them by more than three-to-one, including the Raider's own allies. The Raider will not commandeer their ally's

fleets, but they still count against them in the three-to-one ratio. Similarly, if any of the Raider's fleets are declared At Peace, they will not participate in the commandeer and thus will not count towards the three-to-one ratio; but the Raider does have to outnumber any other fleets at the world, even those that are At Peace.

Commandeer involves only fleets in orbit; I-Ships and P-Ships cannot be commandeered, and these ships do not count toward or against the three-to-one ratio.

At Peace

You may declare any of your fleets to be "at peace." When you so declare a fleet, it will remain "at peace" until you declare otherwise.

Declaring a fleet "at peace" turns off a few otherwise automatic behaviors. A fleet "at peace" will not capture worlds or empty fleet keys, nor will it force empty fleet keys to go neutral. A fleet "at peace" will not frighten an opponent's population away from industry. A Raider's "at peace" fleets will not perform the three-to-one Commandeer. If you are an Missionary, your "at peace" fleets will not make converts on the world below.

That's *all* that "at peace" means. An "at peace" fleet may still attack, or even drop a PBB, if ordered to do so. An "at peace" fleet will even still ambush fire any passing enemy fleets.

Don't be misled into thinking an enemy is necessarily waving a flag of truce simply because you see that their fleets are "at peace."

Artifacts

In addition to fleet keys, you will also find scattered randomly throughout the galaxy a number of indestructible artifacts. For the most part, these artifacts are collectible white elephants, some of which may earn you a few additional points, but most of which have no particular value to most players. You can load as many as you like onto a fleet and carry them from one world to another. (This is not related to carrying metal, and there is no limit to the number of artifacts you can carry on a fleet, regardless of the amount of metal it is already carrying.)

You own an artifact when you own the world (or fleet) on which it is found. Owning certain artifacts will earn you points every turn, while owning certain other artifacts will *cost* you points every turn. Usually the point cost is not large, but it can add up.

Most of the artifacts have a two-part name, consisting of one of the adjectives from the left column below, paired with one of the nouns from the right column:

Imperial	Sceptor
Antique	Sculpture
Savage	Cutlass
Legal	Compact
Metallic	Conduit
Holy	Grail
Venusian	Asteroid
Mythical	Sapphire
Bamboo	Carapace

Cursed

Each combination of words uniquely defines an artifact; for instance, there is one Mythical Sceptor, and there is one Cursed Conduit. With the ten adjectives and nine nouns, this makes for 90 unique artifacts.

In addition to the artifacts described by the above combinations, there are also ten additional special artifacts:

The Key to Time (segments 1 through 5)
The Rock of Diamante
The Rhinovirus
The Philosopher's Stone
The Deadly Nightshade
The Pandora's Box

The one truly special artifact is The Pandora's Box, which has some special behavior, chosen randomly each game.

The other artifacts are worth points only. If you are playing a Collector, of course, they are the key points in the game; but even if you are not a Collector, it may be worthwhile to hang on to these artifacts, to use as bargaining chips should you encounter a Collector who has something you need.

If you want to get rid of one or more artifacts, for instance a cursed or radioactive artifact, you have a number of choices. You could, for instance, hook it onto a fleet and fly the fleet into a Black Hole. Alternatively, you can put it on a world (or fleet) and give the world to another player. If you're lucky enough to know a Collector, you can hook the artifact directly onto one of their passing fleets. But it's usually easiest to fly the fleet over an opponent's or ally's world and just drop it. (You might want to declare your fleet At Peace first so you don't inadvertently capture the world.)

Note that you may directly hook an artifact from your world onto another player's fleet *only* if that player is a Collector. In order to give an artifact to a non-Collector ally, you will have to fly it over one of your ally's worlds and drop it (or, you may give the entire world or fleet holding the artifact to your ally). When using the client, the order to hook an artifact onto another player's fleet will not be offered to you unless you have indicated in the Players panel that the player in question is a Collector.

Pandora's Box

The Pandora's Box does something special every turn that you own it. More often than not, it does something good; but sometimes it's bad. It might, for instance, increase the industry at the world it is located by one every turn; or it might allow the fleet that's carrying it to travel to worlds that aren't actually connected; or it might self-destruct as soon as it's loaded onto a fleet and take all the ships with it.

The Pandora's Box's behavior is chosen at random at the start of the game, and doesn't change during the game. It always does *something,* though sometimes it may be hard to figure out precisely what it does. If you come across it and do successfully figure out what it does, you may gain a key advantage in the game. (Then again, you may not.)

The Number of Artifacts

Although there are 100 uniquely different artifacts, in any particular RSW game there might be fewer than, or more than, this number of artifacts actually distributed throughout the galaxy. This is loosely based on the number of players in the game.

A 15-player game will generally have all 100 artifacts scattered throughout the galaxy. Games with fewer players will have proportionately fewer artifacts (for instance, a 6-player game will typically have 40 artifacts, chosen at random from the full set of 100); and games with more players will have proportionately more artifacts. Furthermore, some games may have more or less than this standard ratio of 100 artifacts per 15 players, according to a random factor chosen at the start of the game.

When a game has more than 100 artifacts, it means that some of the artifacts will be duplicated. For instance, there might be two of the Key to Time, segment 2. If there are, than either of those artifacts will count towards the set of five--but you must also have specifically segments 1, 3, 4, and 5 in order to win the points for having all five segments. Having just a random set of five Key to Time segments that includes some duplicates isn't good enough. Similar restrictions apply to the other collectible groups of artifacts.

Whatever the number of artifacts in a particular game, there will always be exactly one Pandora's Box.

Combat

Any fleet or home fleet may fire at an opponent at the same world. Ships on orbiting fleets have twice as much firepower as I-Ships and P-Ships. Specifically, each ship on a fleet gets one shot (except for a Trader's overloaded ships), while each I-Ship or P-Ship gets only 1/2 shot (except in ambush fire). The odd shot, if any, is rounded down.

In general, it takes two shots to destroy each one of your opponent's ships, but loaded ships are destroyed in one shot. Again, the odd shot is rounded down; and this rounding happens for each firing fleet.

Combat and movement occur simultaneously. If a fleet moves away while you fire at it, it only takes half damage, odd damage rounded down. This rounding happens per targeted fleet.

You cannot simultaneously move and fire a fleet in the same turn.

- Air-to-Ground Fire
- Robot Attacks
- Firing at Converts
- Conditional Fire Orders
- Ambush
- Planet Buster Bombs (PBB's)

Air-to-Ground Fire

You may fire an orbiting fleet at industry. If you do so, your fleet will first destroy any I-Ships, at the standard rate of two shots per one I-Ship, and then it will begin to destroy industry, at the rate of

two shots per one industry.

You may also fire at population. If you do, your fleet will first destroy any P-Ships, at the rate of two shots per one P-Ship, and then it will begin to kill population, at the rate of two shots per one population. Note that, unless you are firing at a robotic population, this means you will be killing civilians; and if you are not a Positronix, or a Missionary firing at your Judged enemy, this will cost you some humanitarian points.

Finally, you may fire an orbiting fleet at home fleets, which is to say, at I-Ships and P-Ships. If you do this, you will first destroy any I-Ships, and then destroy P-Ships, and then if you have fired at least two more shots than necessary to destroy all I-Ships and P-Ships, the world will become neutral (but no damage will be done to actual industry or population). The world will remain neutral--unowned by any player--until there is only one player remaining with ships at the world, according to the standard capture rules.

This is a very useful tactic to deprive the world's owner of its use. It's particularly useful, for instance, if you happen to be lucky enough to be engaging your opponent at their homeworld.

Robot Attacks

A Positronix can issue a special kind of air-to-ground attack. At any time, a Positronix can convert some of the ships on their orbiting fleets to robots, at the rate of two robots for each ship. The robots will fall to the ground below and start killing humans, at the standard rate of four humans to one robot. Thus, each Positronix ship can effectively eliminate eight human population. (You cannot use all of the ships on your fleet in a robot attack; you must leave at least one ship behind to remain on the fleet key.)

If the Positronix thus kills all the population and leaves at least one robot standing, the Positronix will automatically capture the world--including all of its industry, metal, I-Ships, and P-Ships, not to mention any artifacts on the world.

This can therefore be one of the Positronix's deadliest attacks. Ships firing at a fleet performing a robot attack will fire and destroy the falling robots first (at one shot per robot), and then start to destroy ships remaining on the fleet.

Firing at Converts

Your I-Ships or P-Ships on a world may direct their weapons at converts. Each two I-Ships or P-Ships will make one shot, and each one shot will kill one convert.

Killing converts this way may be one of the most effective ways to remove unwanted converts from your world. However, as unpleasant as they are, converts are technically innocent civilians, so unless you are a Positronix, or another Missionary on Judgment, it will cost you points to kill these civilians. Also, unless the Missionary who owns the converts has already pronounced Judgment, you will be awarding them martyr points.

Finally, you may want to be careful that there will be enough people left over after killing all the converts to still work the mines and the industry.

Firing at converts is considered an attack on the Missionary that owns them, and will trigger a conditional fire order.

Conditional Fire Orders

Any of the fire orders may be issued *conditionally.* A conditional fire order means that your ships will not actually fire this turn, unless the player you are targeting fires at you at the same world this turn.

For example, imagine you own F13, and "Harry" owns F37 and F25, and all three fleets are orbiting W12, which you own. If you order F13 to fire *conditionally* at F37, then F13 will fire if and only if Harry fires at you at W12. That means, for instance, if F37 fires at F13; or if F25 fires at your population--both of these are attacks by Harry towards you at W12, so either attack would trigger your conditional attack, and your F13 will open fire at F37. But if Harry decided not to attack you (or if Harry also issued just conditional fire orders), then your conditional orders would not be triggered, and there would be no violence. This is true even if Harry did fire on you at some other world.

Conditional fire orders are often issued during tense negotiations.

A conditional fire order is considered an action--you cannot issue a conditional fire order and a movement order in the same turn, and issuing a conditional fire order will prevent your fleet from ambushing, even if the fire order is not triggered.

The conditional nature of your fire order will not be obvious to other players. If the fire order is triggered, to other players seeing the world it will look the same as if you had issued a regular, non-conditional fire order. If the fire order is not triggered, it will look to other players as if you did not fire at all.

Ambush

Any ships you have at a world, whether they are I-Ships or P-Ships, or ships on fleets, that were not already moving or firing, will normally fire automatically at any enemy's fleets that move through the world without stopping (that is, fleets that move in multiple hops at once, enroute to a different world).

When ships fire in ambush mode, they do double damage. Furthermore, I-Ships and P-Ships will ambush fire at the same strength as orbiting fleets (instead of at half that strength), so each I-Ship, P-Ship, or fleet ship that ambush fires can destroy one unloaded ship, or two loaded ships.

As if that weren't enough, ambushing ships can fire at multiple different targets in the same turn--so if an enemy attempts to bring more than one fleet through your world without stopping, your I-Ships, P-Ships, and fleets at that world will ambush fire at *each* of them, doing double damage to each enemy fleet.

There are some very important things to understand about ambush. First, it *only* applies when an enemy attempts to pass completely through a world enroute to another world, using multiple hops. That is, only the ships at the fleet's intermediate stops, if any, can ambush. The ships at a fleet's final destination will not ambush fire. (You do not have to be the owner of the world in order for your fleets to ambush fire at that world.)

Second, only those ships that did not not receive an explicit move or fire order will ambush fire. If you ordered a fleet to move, or if you ordered a fleet to fire at some target (even a conditional fire order that isn't fulfilled), then that fleet will not ambush that turn. Similarly, if you ordered your I-Ships or P-Ships to fire, then they will not ambush.

You will not ambush fire at your allies. However, ships declared At Peace will still ambush.

It is possible to turn off the auto-ambush feature at any particular world or worlds, or at all worlds you own, for a given turn. This is only very rarely done. You might do this, for instance, to extend safe-passage to an opponent through a particular set of worlds, without having to declare that opponent an ally.

The ambush rule helps you to defend your inner circle of worlds with I-Ships and P-Ships, forcing your enemies to approach slowly, one turn at a time, or risk being decimated by your ambush fire.

Planet Buster Bombs (PBB's)

Any time you have at least 26 ships on a fleet, you may build a Planet Buster Bomb. Just as its name implies, this is a fearsome weapon that, when deployed, completely obliterates all signs of life on a world and leaves it a smoldering dustheap. Population, population limit, mines, metal, industry, I-Ships, and P-Ships are all reduced to 0. (Any artifacts on the world are unaffected; also, orbiting fleets are not affected.)

Although any character type can build and drop a PBB, it is generally the Positronixes in a game who are most likely to build PBB's. This is because Positronixes gain 200 points for dropping a PBB (plus two points per human population killed), while most other players stand to lose 50 points for dropping a PBB (minus an additional point for each human population killed). However, a Missionary on Judgment will also be seen to drop the occasional PBB--a post-Judgment Missionary will incur no penalty for PBB'ing their enemy, and will stand to gain points from the heathen population killed.

It costs 25 ships to build a PBB, and you must leave at least one ship behind on the fleet. You may want to have more than one additional ship, though, since if an opponent fires at your PBB-bearing fleet and destroys all the ships on it, even on the round you are trying to drop the PBB, the PBB will not drop, and your fleet (and its PBB) will be lost. When a fleet carrying a PBB changes hands, the PBB disappears; you cannot capture a PBB from another player.

Everyone who sees your fleet will know that it is carrying a PBB. You can build a PBB and move the fleet in the same turn, but you cannot build the PBB and drop it in the same turn.

Dropping a PBB is considered a fire order. You cannot move the fleet and drop a PBB in the same turn, and you cannot fire the fleet at another target in the same turn. Dropping a PBB is considered an attack on the owner of the world, and will trigger conditional attack orders.

Character Types and Scoring

One of the things that makes RSW particularly exciting is the different character types and the way they interact. Although each character type has at least one special ability not shared by any other character type, the primary difference between them is handled in the way that points are awarded--which thus determines each player's primary motivation in the game.

- The Emperor
- The Collector
- The Raider
- The Trader
- The Positronix
- The Missionary

The above are the default six character types available in a standard Classic game. There are also several additional character types that are available in an Advanced game:

- The Architect
- The Arms Dealer
- The Skip Tracer
- The Scavenger
- The Warlord

Beyond character type, there are also a few other things that influence score:

- Artifact Points
- Miscellaneous Penalties

The Emperor

The Emperor is the simplest to understand of the various character types, and possibly the easiest to play. As an Emperor, your goal is to acquire as much of the galaxy in your own name as possible. Whatever it is, you must have more!

The Emperor earns points each turn according to the following schedule:

Each 10 population on a world	1
Each unit of industry	1
Each mine	1

The Emperor is also able to build industry more easily than any other character type. Most players require 5 metal to build 1 industry; you require only 4 (in the Advanced game, only 3). Also, most players must scrap 6 I-Ships to make 1 industry, while you can do it with only 4 I-Ships.

As an Emperor, you will need a solid mastery of diplomacy to persuade other players to yield their worlds to you--and it wouldn't hurt to have a good handle on battle tactics for when diplomacy fails!

The Collector

The Collector has tastes that tend to the eclectic. As a Collector, you eschew such worldly things as worlds and industry; you crave only to own the strange artifacts left behind by some long-forgotten alien race.

The Collector earns points solely for owning artifacts:

Your one "greatest treasure" (that is, the Antique Sculpture)	90
Any half-treasure, except Cursed (any Antique or Sculpture)	30

Any Cursed item	0
Any of the five Key to Time segments	0
The Rock of Diamante	30
The Rhinovirus	30
The Philosopher's Stone	30
The Deadly Nightshade	30
The Pandora's Box	30
Any other artifact	15

The above points are awarded each turn that you hold one of the indicated items. In addition, there are special bonus points that are awarded, once, at the end of the game, for holding a matched set:

Ending with all five segments of the Key to Time	1500
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special type (all the Antique objects)	1000
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special noun (all the Sculpture objects), except Cursed	1000
Each world you own with at least 10 artifacts at the end of the game (this is a "museum")	500

Note that, in particular game (particularly in a game with fewer than 15 players), not all of the possible artifacts may be available in the galaxy, and so it might not be possible to accumulate all the artifacts of a matched set--for instance, it might or might not be possible to collect all nine Antique artifacts. See The Number of Artifacts for more information.

The Collector is the only player that never loses points for holding any artifacts, so you can take advantage of this and offer to take Cursed artifacts (or The Deadly Nightshade!) off the hands of your unfortunate companions.

Also, only the Collector may transfer artifacts directly from fleet to fleet, making it fairly easy for you to move artifacts around the galaxy. Other players must transfer them strictly world-to-fleet or fleet-to-world. Furthermore, other players may give you artifacts by hooking them directly onto your fleets, instead of having to fly over one of your worlds and drop them.

The Raider

As a Raider, you will sweep in and take what is yours, leaving nothing but crumbs for those who come behind!

The Raider gains points for plunder. You can plunder any world that you own. This renders the world useless for the next three turns--it won't produce metal from its mines or build with its industry--but it gives you lots of points!

You can plunder the same world over and over again (once it has recovered from the last plunder, which will be after three turns), but each time you plunder the same world, you get fewer and fewer points. You get 50 points the first time you plunder a particular world, 40 points the second time, 30 points the third time, 20 points the fourth time, and thereafter you only get 10 points each time. (In the Advanced game, the Raider earns 100 points the first time, then 80, 60, 40, and 20 points thereafter.) For this reason, a Raider must constantly be on the prowl for fresh worlds to plunder.

As a Raider, you have an important special ability: any time the ships on your fleets outnumber the ships on your opponents' fleets at a given world by more than 3 to 1, you will automatically Commandeer all of their ships and fleets, and capture them wholesale! This special capture occurs automatically, without firing a single shot. (Though if you can bring your opponents down below the 3-to-1 ratio by shooting at them a bit, so much the better.)

Since capturing fleets is such an important Raider ability, you will also gain an additional 3 points per turn for each fleet that you own. In the Advanced game (but not in the Classic game), you will also gain an additional 1 point per each 10 ships you own.

Playing a Raider can be a lot of fun, but playing it well can be a challenge. Since your earning potential becomes smaller as the game goes on (unless you are very good at finding new worlds to conquer), it is important for a Raider to try to win the game quickly.

The Trader

A Trader earns points for delivering metal to other players. Metal is the lifeblood of the game; it is what drives each player's industry and is what is needed to build ships (or robots). Thus, a Trader is usually welcome anywhere.

As a Trader, you earn 8 points for each unit of metal that you deliver to another player (only 6 points in the Advanced game). You can deliver metal simply by unloading it on another player's world, and you get points for all the metal that you unload, up to twice the number of industry that they have on that world. For example, if you deliver metal to another player's world that has 3 industry, you can get up to 48 points at that world, by dropping 6 metal there, at 8 points each.

You also gain points for unloading consumer goods, at any world (even worlds that you own). Consumer goods are metal that you have converted to valuable commodities such as DVD players and bobble-head dolls; you can convert it as you unload it. You gain the same number of points for unloading consumer goods regardless of the number you unload, so there's no advantage pointwise for unloading more than 1 consumer good at a time. You can unload consumer goods over and over again at the same world, but each time you do, you earn fewer points. The first time you unload consumer goods at a particular world, you earn 10 points. The second time, you earn 8 points; the third time, 5 points; and the fourth time, 3 points. After that you only earn 1 point each time you unload consumer goods at a given world.

As a Trader, you can carry twice as much metal in your fleets as any other player. Most players can carry only one metal per ship, but you can carry as much as two metal per ship. However, when you do this, you have to take your weapons systems offline to make room for the extra metal, so your overloaded ships cannot fire. (You can fire as soon as you get rid of the extra metal, by jettisoning it if you have to.)

Clearly, a Trader will need to work closely with other players to succeed in the game.

The Positronix

The Positronix is a race of robotic beings that were created long ago for the sole purpose of extinguishing life, specifically humanity, wherever they find it. As a Positronix, you are interested only in your goal of killing as many people as possible.

Positronixes can build robots. Lots of robots. You can build robots directly with your industry (you can build 2 robots for each one metal) or you can convert any of your ships on fleets to robots (2 robots for each ship) and drop them on the world below.

Whenever you mix robots and humans, they always kill each other off. Each four humans will kill one robot, and vice-versa. If you kill all of the human population on a world and replace it with robots, you have a robotic world. Robotic populations can work the industry and mines just like normal populations, although they don't automatically grow like normal populations do--you have to build more robots if you need more population. On the other hand, robots can ignore the world's population limit.

Other non-Positronix players cannot capture your robotic worlds; only another Positronix can own a world populated by robots. If you convert your ships to robots and drop enough on another player's world to kill off all their human population, leaving at least one robot, you will automatically capture the world. This makes a particularly effective attack!

Finally, the Positronix is the master of the PBB: The Planet Buster Bomb! You can build a PBB on any of your fleets by converting 25 of your ships, leaving at least one ship to drive the fleet. At any subsequent turn you can drop the PBB to the world below, completely annihilating all life, destroying industry and mines, and generally leaving the planet a smoking, uninhabitable ruin (inhabitable only by robots, in fact). All other players fear the Positronix's PBB!

Positronixes earn points according to the following schedule:

Each population killed	2
Each enemy ship destroyed (you must destroy the entire fleet)	2
Each all-robotic world owned	5
Each PBB dropped	200 + population (Advanced game: 100 + population)

The Positronix is the fiercest fighter of all the character types. However, even a Positronix has been known to strike up a temporary alliance with a life form or two (if doing so will further their ultimate goal of destroying all life).

The Missionary

The Missionary is a religious fanatic, driven to spread their Truth throughout the galaxy. As a Missionary, you will diligently work to make converts to your religion at every world you visit.

Every turn, each ship you have on a fleet not At Peace has a 10% chance of converting one population on the world below to your religion. Once you have converts on the world, the converts themselves will also convert more population: each convert has a 10% chance of converting an additional population every turn. If you own the world, then any normal population growth will be all converts.

Finally, you can migrate converts to a neighboring world from any world that has industry--you can migrate one convert per unit of industry (and metal), each turn.

You will continue to get reports on a world every turn you have converts there, even if you lose ownership of it (or never had ownership of it). If at any time the converts reach 100% of the population, you will automatically capture the world, even if your ships are nowhere near it. Likewise, another player cannot capture any world from you that is 100% converts, unless they manage to convert some of them back first.

Another player can try to un-convert your converts by bribing them with consumer goods. Each consumer good unloaded at a world has a 50% chance of unconverting one convert. Alternatively, a player can fire at the converts, killing them (but they become martyrs to your cause, earning you points).

As a Missionary, you are generally a pacifist. You *lose* points for firing at other players. However, you may pronounce Judgment at any point during the game, naming *one* other player as your enemy. Once you have pronounced Judgment, you will from that point on no longer lose points for firing at your declared enemy (but you still lose points for firing at other players). In fact, you will gain points for each of your enemy's population that you kill. You cannot unpronounce Judgment, but you can pronounce a new Judgment against a different enemy; this will replace the previous Judgment. You can change your mind about who your enemy is every turn, if you like, but each turn there is only one particular enemy.

Once you have pronounced Judgment, you no longer gain points for people killing your converts, no matter who kills them.

A Missionary on Judgment is the only character type besides a Positronix who can drop a PBB (a Planet Buster Bomb) without losing points--provided you drop it on a world owned by your declared enemy.

Missionaries earn points according to the following tables.

In the Classic game, before pronouncing Judgment:

Each convert killed by another player (martyrs)	1
Each shot fired	-1
Each world owned	5
Each world with 100% converts	5
Each 10 converts	1

In the Classic game, after pronouncing Judgment:

Each convert killed by another player	0
Each shot fired at your enemy	0
Each shot fired at someone else	-1
Each enemy population killed	2
Dropping a PBB on your enemy	0 (+ population)
Each world owned	5
Each world with 100% converts	5
Each 10 converts	1

In the Advanced game, before pronouncing Judgment:

Each convert killed by another player (martyrs)	2

Each shot fired	-1
Each world owned	5
Each world with 100% converts	5
Each 5 converts	1

In the Advanced game, after pronouncing Judgment:

Each convert killed by another player	1
Each shot fired at your enemy	0
Each shot fired at someone else	-1
Each enemy population killed	3
Dropping a PBB on your enemy	0 (+ population)
Each world owned	5
Each world with 100% converts	5
Each 5 converts	1

Artifact Points

Each character type collects extra points for owning certain artifacts, according to the following table:

Emperor	Imperial Sceptor
Collector	Antique Sculpture
Raider	Savage Cutlass
Trader	Legal Compact
Positronix	Metallic Conduit
Missionary	Holy Grail
Architect	(no special)
Arms Dealer	Venusian Asteroid
Skip Tracer	Bamboo Carapace
Scavenger	Bamboo Carapace
Warlord	Mythical Sapphire

That is, the Emperor gets extra points for owning the Imperial Sceptor, while the Raider gets extra points for owning the Savage Cutlass, and so on. In addition to the bonus points each character class gets for owning its one special artifact, each character class also gets some points (though not quite as many) for owning an artifact which has at least one word in common with that character classes' special artifact; for instance, a Positronix will get some points for owning a Metallic Grail or an Mythical Conduit.

Furthermore, each player (except a Collector) will *lose* points for owning any of the Cursed artifacts, even if is the player's special object noun. (A Positronix loses points for owning a Cursed Conduit, even though it is a Conduit.)

The following table shows the per-turn score value for each artifact. Collectors earn points based on a different table from all of the other character types.

For non-Collectors (except Architect):

Your one "greatest treasure" (e.g. a Positronix holding the Metallic Conduit)	15

Any half-treasure, except Cursed (e.g. a Positronix with a Metallic Grail or Mythical Conduit)	5
Any Cursed item	-10
Any of the five Key to Time segments	0
The Rock of Diamante	10
The Rhinovirus	-15
The Philosopher's Stone	20
The Deadly Nightshade	-30
The Pandora's Box	0
Any other artifact	0

For Collectors:

Your one "greatest treasure" (that is, the Antique Sculpture)	90
Any half-treasure, except Cursed (any Antique or Sculpture)	30
Any Cursed item	0
Any of the five Key to Time segments	0
The Rock of Diamante	30
The Rhinovirus	30
The Philosopher's Stone	30
The Deadly Nightshade	30
The Pandora's Box	30
Any other artifact	15

Note that the Architect, a character type available in the Advanced game, makes no distinction between artifact types, and earns a uniform 5 points per turn for each artifact, including Cursed artifacts.

The above points are awarded each turn that you hold one of the indicated items. In addition, there are special bonus points that are awarded, once, at the end of the game, for holding a matched set:

For non-Collectors:

Ending with all five segments of the Key to Time (includes Architect)	1000
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special type (e.g., for a Positronix, all the Metallic objects)	500
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special noun (e.g., for a Positronix, all the Conduit objects), except Cursed	500

For Collectors:

Ending with all five segments of the Key to Time	1500
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special type (all the Antique objects)	1000
Ending with all nine artifacts of your special noun (all the Sculpture objects), except Cursed	1000
Each world with at least 10 artifacts at the end of the game	500

Miscellaneous Penalties

In addition to the scoring for each character class, there are some standard penalties for certain antihumanitarian behaviors which apply to most character classes.

Each non-robotic population killed (except Positronixes and Missionaries against their enemy)	-1
Each PBB dropped (except Positronixes and Missionaries against their enemy)	-50 (+ population)
Each world plundered (except Raiders)	-5

The Architect

An Architect controls the technology that creates and destroys the connections between worlds, known as Starbridges. This makes the Architect a powerful force for changing the topology of the universe.

Manipulating the space-time continuum to make Starbridges is not cheap, however. An Architect does this by cannibalizing the stardrives and engines of their fleets, sacrificing ships (sometimes many ships) for the resulting Starbridge.

In order to build or destroy a Starbridge, two fleets are required, one at each end where a connection is to be made or destroyed. In order to move an existing Starbridge, three fleets are required. No fleets involved in the process may move or fire in the same turn. Starbridges are created after combat, so all fleets must survive any combat in order to successfully perform their operation.

Constructing a new Starbridge

Constructing a Starbridge requires two fleets, one at each end of the connection: an Executor fleet, and a Receiving fleet. The Executor fleet must contain a sufficient number of ships for the construction operation (and these ships will be consumed by the operation). If an opponent fires on this fleet and destroys some of the required ships, the construction operation will fail.

The number of ships required, as well as the points awarded, are based on the distance between the worlds (number of hops) *before* the construction of the bridge itself, according to the following schedule:

Number of hops	Ships required	Points awarded
2	10	100
3	20	200
4	30	300
5	50	500
6	80	800
7	130	1300
8 or more	210	2100

If the Starbridge is successfully constructed, it can be used on the next turn, but the wormhole connection is initially very unstable. The Receiving fleet must then fly through the newly made connection, back to the original location of the Executor fleet, in order to stabilize the Starbridge and make it permanent. If this is not done (whether intentionally, accidently or due to the destruction of the Receiving fleet) then the Starbridge will collapse: this connection will not exist the following turn.

Architects are proud creatures and want their works to last forever. Any Starbridge that fails to form will not score points. Any Starbridge that collapses the turn following its creation will deduct a penalty of points equal to half of those awarded for the creation of the Starbridge.

Destroying a Starbridge

Destroying a Starbridge is a similar operation. Like construction, destruction requires an Executor fleet and a Receiving fleet, positioned at opposite ends of the connection to be destroyed. The Executor fleet must contain sufficient ships for the destruction operation, or the operation will fail.

The cost of destroying a Starbridge, and the points awarded, follow the same table given above for construction. In this case the cost is based on the number of hops that will exist between the worlds *after* the Starbridge is destroyed.

Note that since the cost of destroying a Starbridge is based on the resulting distance between the two worlds, it is not possible to destroy a connection and leave no path at all between the two worlds.

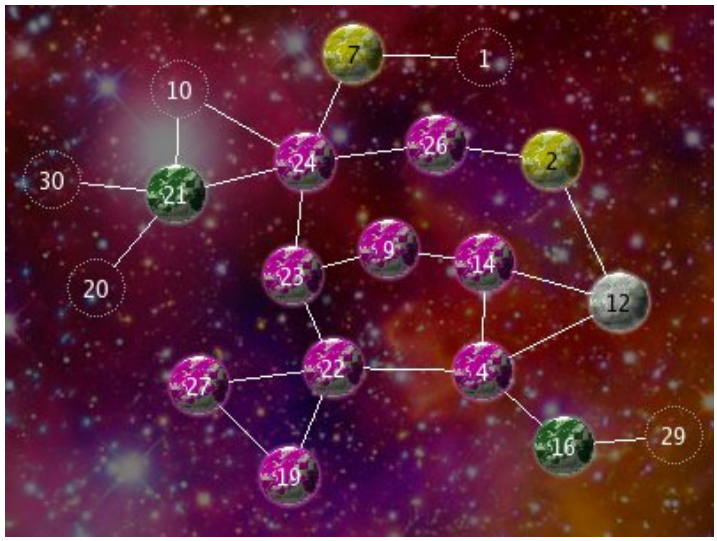
Moving a Starbridge

Rather than destroying or creating a Starbridge outright, it may be more economical simply to *move* an existing Starbridge from one world to another world. This operation requires three fleets: one Executor fleet, and two Receiving fleets. The original Starbridge must be connected from the Executor fleet's world to the first Receiving fleet's world; after the operation, it will connect from the Executor fleet's world to the second Receiving fleet's world. As with construction, above, the second Receiving fleet must still fly back through the new connection as soon as it is established, or the Starbridge will collapse on the following turn and revert to its original structure.

The cost of moving a Starbridge, and the points awarded, are based on the number of hops the Starbridge is *moved.* That is, the cost is based on the number of hops between the two Receiving fleet worlds. This follows the same schedule above, although there is a new entry for moving a Starbridge only one world: this costs 5 ships and awards 50 points.

Examples

Consider the following sample map:



An Architect with a fleet at World 27 and a fleet at World 23 can create a Starbridge between them at a cost of 10 ships. If they initiate the operation from World 27, that fleet is the Executor fleet, and loses 10 ships in the operation; the next turn, the fleet at World 23 must fly through the newly-established connection to return to World 27.

To construct a Starbridge between World 27 and World 2, however, would cost 30 ships (those worlds are four hops apart).

To destroy the connection between World 27 and World 22 would require a fleet at each world, and would cost 10 ships, since the worlds would be two hops apart after the operation. However, to destroy the connection between World 22 and World 4 would cost 30 ships, since destroying that connection would make the worlds four hops apart.

To *move* the W27-W22 connection to W27-W23 would require an Executor fleet at World 27, and a Receiver fleet at each of Worlds 22 and 23. This operation would cost 5 ships, since World 22 is only one hop from World 23. To move W27-W22 to W27-W2 would cost 20 ships (three hops). Note that this is cheaper than connecting W27 to W2 directly.

Finally, note that to move W22-W23 to W22-W16 is considered moving the connection four hops, and will cost 30 ships. Strictly speaking, the number of hops between W23 and W16 is only three; but you can't move the Starbridge through itself, so you have to count the distance the longer away around, which is a distance of four hops.

Additional Points

The whole purpose of Starbridge technology is to find more worlds and art for the Architect empire. Thus, the Architect receives an additional:

5 points per world owned

5 points per artifact owned

The Arms Dealer

An Arms Dealer's sole interest is the selling of arms. To be specific, ships. The Arms Dealer's special ability is to convert metal stores into ships aboard their fleets which act as orbital industrial complexes. Once built, the ships are automatically delivered to the home fleets of their happy customers.

In any given turn, an Arms Dealer can convert some or all of the metal in the cargo hold of their fleet into a number of new ships on the ground, and the metal is consumed in this process. During the turn that the Arms Dealer is building, they may not fire or move the fleet. The newly-built ships may not fire in the turn they are built either. The metal must already have been loaded onto the fleet on some previous turn.

In order to deliver product to customers, Arms Dealers have developed special drive engines that allow their fleets to fly through up to 4 consecutive worlds in a single turn (instead of the standard 3). Furthermore, like Traders, their fleets can carry extra metal; up to 3 units of metal per ship. On the other hand, Arms Dealers are terrible fighters--their weapons fire at 1/4 the strength of standard weapons, and when fired upon, an Arms Dealer's ship will take double the standard amount of damage.

- Every ship created requires that the Arms Dealer fleet contains 1 ship and 2 metal at the beginning of the turn. The metal is consumed in the process.
- Fleets may move through up to 4 worlds in one turn.
- Fleets may carry up to 3 metal per ship.
- Fleets fire 1/4 shot per ship; overloaded ships cannot fire.
- Fleets take twice the damage when shot, e.g. 1 shot destroys 1 ship (or 2 loaded with metal). Damage from ambush fire is also twice as heavy, so that 1 P-ship can destroy 2 fleet ships in ambush.
- The Arms Dealer receives 11 points per ship created on a world they own, and 22 points per ship created on a world owned by another player.

The Skip Tracer

These creatures are master trackers and mappers in the universe. They are powerful spies but not very strong militarily.

Each Skip Tracer gets a probe of every world connected to a world that they own. A Skip Tracer fleet can fly through up to 4 connected worlds per turn, like an Arms Dealer. Also, Skip Tracers have the ability to fly into a black hole, completely unharmed! Skip Tracers can navigate through a black hole as easily as any other world.

Skip Tracers are adept at evading ambushes while mapping unallied territories. Unfortunately, their fleets pay for their increased maneuverability, and only carry light arms. The Skip Tracer earns points for discovering new worlds and traveling to all worlds.

- Fleets may move through up to 4 worlds in one turn.
- Fleets will survive a visit to a black hole, and can move through them safely.
- Fleets only fire 1/2 shot per ship.
- Fleets only take 1/2 damage from ambush (e.g., 10 I-Ships ambush firing upon a Skip Tracer would only destroy 5 unloaded ships).

Scoring:

- Each world seen for the first time, whether it is by probe, visit, or fly-through = 15 points.
- Each world seen for the second or subsequent times = 5 points each turn seen.

The Scavenger

This race is quite adept at scrounging, salvaging and repairing damaged ships. They are not above outright theft of neutral keys as well.

In combat (as well as in ambush fire) a Scavenger's fleet can salvage 25% of the destroyed enemy ships. This happens automatically whenever a Scavenger fleet fires on an enemy: 25% of the destroyed ships, rounded down, are automatically added to the firing fleet.

If the firing fleet is destroyed, no ships will be salvaged. Only surviving fleets can salvage, and only for the damage they caused (not for additional damage caused by allied fleets).

In addition to this, a Scavenger can claim neutral keys as their own, despite the presence of other players with fleets not at peace. To do this, the Scavenger's ships outnumber all the non-allied ships at the same world by more than 2-to-1; if so, then all neutral, unowned keys at that world are automatically awarded to the Scavenger. (This is similar to a Raider's Commandeering, except it only works for neutral keys.)

Scoring:

- Each ship captured via salvage = 20 points.
- Each key owned = 15 points.

The Warlord

This race thrills to the call to battle. The Warlord excels in raw firepower: A Warlord's fleets fire 50% more shots in combat or in ambush. In addition, a Warlord can capture and hold enemy worlds even if they are fully populated by converts or robots.

A Warlord has a long memory, and if slighted, can selectively target another race (similar to a Missionary's Judgment target). A Warlord can specify their target opponent at any time. They can change their mind about who is the target each turn, but there may be only one target per turn. A Warlord scores by destroying enemy ships, capturing fleets and worlds, and receives double points when firing at their declared target. Unlike a Positronix, a Warlord gets points for each ship destroyed, even if the entire fleet is not destroyed.

Scoring:

- Points Per Ship Destroyed = 10
- Points Per Target Ship Destroyed = 20
- Points Per Fleet Captured = 20
- Points Per Target Fleet Captured = 40
- Points Per World Captured = 100
- Points Per Target World Captured = 200

Miscellaneous Rules

These chapters describe some of the more esoteric or advanced rules of the game. If you are a beginner, it may not be important for you to understand these in detail, but you should plan to come back and read this section in detail as you gain a mastery of the game.

- Capturing Worlds and Fleets
- Gifts
- Allies, Loaders, and Teammates
- Order Codes
- Turn Phases: the sequence of actions within a turn

Capturing Worlds and Fleets

The rules for ownership of worlds and fleets are fundamentally simple: you will automatically capture any world or fleet when you are the only player there with ships not at peace.

That is to say, if you bring a fleet to a world, and there is no other player with fleets at that world, and there are no I-Ships or P-Ships on that world, then you will become the new owner of the world, as well as of any (empty) fleet keys at that world.

On the other hand, if two different players bring their fleets to a world at the same time, then ownership of the world does not automatically change (though it may go neutral if a player subsequently fires at home fleets; see Air-to-Ground fire). Combat aside, if the world was previously owned by anyone, it will remain owned by that player. If the world was previously neutral, it will remain neutral. If there are any empty fleet keys at the world, they will become neutral (even if they were previously owned by a player).

This means that if you want to prevent your worlds from being captured by the first player to bring a fleet there, you must leave at least one I-Ship or P-Ship at the world. The presence of this ship will count as a ship in your name, and will also serve to keep ownership of the world in your name as well (unless the other player fires at your ship and destroys it, but that will take an additional turn).

Any fleets that you declare to be At Peace don't count towards this rule. If you bring a fleet "at peace" to a world at the same time another player brings a fleet not "at peace" to the world, the other player will capture the world.

Also, you will not capture worlds from your allies, even if you are the only player there and your fleets are not "at peace". But having a fleet not "at peace" at an ally's world *will* serve to prevent another player from capturing the world.

Note that if you have any empty fleet keys at a world, you will lose ownership of them if another player brings a fleet there, even an ally. At the best, they will become neutral; and at the worst, they will be owned by the newcomer. If you want to keep ownership of your fleet keys, it is best to keep at least one ship on each one.

Also note that Commandeering and gifts will change ownership of a fleet, but since both of these occur after the world-capture test is made, for the purposes of capturing the world the fleet is considered owned by its previous owner. The world will not change hands as a result of a fleet gift or Raider capture until the next turn.

No one can own a world that has zero population. If you need to capture a world with no population, you will have to migrate people there from a neighboring world--unless you are lucky enough to be a Positronix, in which case you can simply drop a robot or two from one of your fleets.

If the world's population is robotic, only a Positronix can own the world. So even if you are the only player to bring a fleet to a Positronix's robotic world, unless you are also a Positronix, you will not capture the world from them.

If the world's population is 100% converts, you cannot capture the world unless you first eliminate some of the converts, for instance by unloading consumer goods.

Gifts

You may arbitrarily give any world or fleet you own to any player you have met in the game. The ownership is transferred without question.

There are several important limitations on gifts. You may not fire or move a fleet in the same turn that you give it away. You may not fire with a world's I-Ships or P-Ships in the turn that you give it away (you may still build with its industry, however).

You may only make up to two gifts per turn.

Gift exchanges occur at the end of the turn. If the world is captured from you the same turn that you give it, the gift fails.

Allies, Loaders, and Teammates

Allies

You can declare any player you meet in the game to be an *ally*. This instructs the game not to do certain things which would otherwise be automatic:

- You will not capture an ally's worlds or fleets (but your presence will still force an ally's empty fleet to go neutral, unless you declare your own fleet At Peace).
- Raiders will not commandeer an ally's fleets.
- You will not ambush an ally passing through your worlds.
- Your fleets will not prevent an ally's industry from building.

Note that declaring someone your ally doesn't necessarily mean that you trust them or even that you intend to work with them. All it does is disable the above automatic systems against that player, until you declare them no longer an ally.

The other player will *not* be told that you have declared them your ally. Note that there's no reason to assume that the other player has also declared *you* an ally!

Loaders

In addition to declaring alliances, you may declare any player you meet to be a *loader*. This gives the named player implicit permission to load metal from any of your worlds. This is often done to

facilitate arrangements with Traders; it may also be offered sometimes during diplomatic talks as an easily-verifiable sign of goodwill.

Teammates

The concept of "teammate" is specific to the RSW Client, and replaces the server-based concepts of "allies" and "loaders".

If you are playing the game using the RSW Client, the default behavior is for the client to manage both ally and loader settings according to your team assignments. If you define a team that includes yourself, any players you also assign to the team will be declared as both allies and loaders. Removing a player from your team will undeclare that player as an ally and loader.

If you prefer to manage allies and loaders explicitly, you can turn off this default behavior of the client in the Teams panel. This will give you more control over declaring allies and loaders, but you will have to remember to do it yourself.

Order Codes

It is not necessary to memorize, or even to know, any of the following order codes if you use the RSW Client to play the game. However, if you are an advanced player, you may find it useful to know at least some of them; you can type any of these orders directly by pressing Control+Y in the game window.

If you use the web interface or the email interface to play RSW, you *must* use these order codes to enter your orders.

In the table below, lowercase sequences like *aa* or *bb* stand for a numeric fleet, world, or artifact index. The sequence *xx* stands for a count of ships, population, etc. (The use of doubled letters here is simply for readability; it does not imply the index numbers must be strictly two digits.)

For instance, the order F32T4F5, which is an example of the first of the transfer orders in the table, means to transfer 4 ships from fleet 32 to fleet 5. Note that each order must be entered as a single word, with no intervening punctuation or spaces between the parts of the order. Case is not important (you may enter the order in either uppercase or lowercase).

Note that the sequence in which you type your orders does not matter--the game will execute orders in a particular, predefined sequence, which has nothing to do with the order in which you typed them. This execution order is roughly reflected in the below table. For instance, transfer orders are always executed before build orders, which are executed before movement and fire orders, and so on. For a precise description of the turn's execution order, see Turn Phases.

Ambush control

Z	Turn off auto-ambush at all worlds (for one turn)
Z*aa*	Turn off auto-ambush at world *aa* (for one turn)

Alliances, Judgments, and Gifts

A=handle	Declare player "handle" your ally
N=handle	Declare player "handle" is no longer your ally
L=handle	Declare player "handle" is allowed to load metal from your worlds
X=handle	Declare player "handle" is no longer allowed to load your metal

J=handle	Pronounce Judgment against player "handle"
F*aa*G=handle	Give fleet *aa* to player "handle"
W*aa*G=handle	Give world *aa* to player "handle"

"At Peace" management

F*aa*Q	Declare fleet *aa* is at peace
F*aa*X	Declare fleet *aa* is not at peace

Transfer ships from place to place

F*aa*T*xx*F*bb*	Transfer *xx* ships from fleet *aa* to fleet *bb*
F*aa*T*xx*I	Transfer *xx* ships from fleet *aa* to I-Ships
F*aa*T*xx*P	Transfer *xx* ships from fleet *aa* to P-Ships
I*aa*T*xx*F*bb*	Transfer *xx* I-Ships on world *aa* to fleet *bb*
P*aa*T*xx*F*bb*	Transfer *xx* P-Ships on world *aa* to fleet *bb*
P*aa*T*xx*I	Transfer *xx* P-Ships on world *aa* to I-Ships
I*aa*T*xx*P	Transfer *xx* I-Ships on world *aa* to P-Ships

Build

W*aa*B*xx*I	Build *xx* I-Ships at world *aa*
W*aa*B*xx*P	Build *xx* P-Ships at world *aa*
W*aa*B*xx*F*bb*	Build *xx* ships onto fleet *bb* at world *aa*
W*aa*I*xx*I	Build *xx* new industry at world *aa*
W*aa*I*xx*L	Increase population limit at world *aa* by *xx*
W*aa*B*xx*R	Build robots at world *aa* using *xx* industry
W*aa*S*xx*	Create *xx* new industry on world *aa* by scrapping I-Ships
F*aa*B*xx*I	Build *xx* I-Ships using the ships and metal on fleet *aa*†
F*aa*B*xx*P	Build *xx* P-Ships using the ships and metal on fleet *aa*†

Migrate population

P*aa*M*xx*W*bb*	Migrate *xx* population from world *aa* to world *bb*
C*aa*M*xx*W*bb*	Migrate *xx* converts from world *aa* to world *bb*

Load and unload metal

F*aa*U	Unload all metal from fleet *aa*
F*aa*U*xx*	Unload *xx* metal from fleet *aa*
F*aa*J	Jettison all metal from fleet *aa*
F*aa*J*xx*	Jettison *xx* metal from fleet *aa*
F*aa*N	Unload all metal from fleet *aa* as consumer goods
F*aa*N*xx*	Unload *xx* metal from fleet *aa* as consumer goods
F*aa*L	Load all possible metal onto fleet *aa*
F*aa*L*xx*	Load *xx* metal onto fleet *aa*

Hook and unhook artifacts from fleets

V*aa*F*bb*	Hook artifact number *aa* onto fleet *bb*
V*aa*W	Drop artifact number *aa* to world

Unconditional fire orders and other combat

F*aa*AF*bb*	Fire fleet *aa* at fleet *bb*
I*aa*AF*bb*	Fire I-Ships on world *aa* at fleet *bb*
P*aa*AF*bb*	Fire P-Ships on world *aa* at fleet *bb*
F*aa*AI	Fire fleet *aa* at I-Ships and Industry
F*aa*AP	Fire fleet *aa* at P-Ships and Population
F*aa*AH	Fire fleet *aa* at I-Ships and P-Ships
I*aa*AC	Fire I-Ships on world *aa* at converts
P*aa*AC	Fire P-Ships on world *aa* at converts
F*aa*B	Build a PBB on fleet *aa*
F*aa*D	Drop a PBB from fleet *aa*
F*aa*R*xx*	Convert *xx* ships to robots and drop on world

F*aa*S	Order fleet *aa* to stand by for ambush fire*

Conditional fire orders

F*aa*CF*bb*	Conditionally fire fleet *aa* at fleet *bb*
I*aa*CF*bb*	Conditionally fire I-Ships on world *aa* at fleet *bb*
P*aa*CF*bb*	Conditionally fire P-Ships on world *aa* at fleet *bb*
F*aa*CI	Conditionally fire fleet *aa* at I-Ships and Industry
F*aa*CP	Conditionally fire fleet *aa* at P-Ships and Population
F*aa*CH	Conditionally fire fleet *aa* at I-Ships and P-Ships
I*aa*CC	Conditionally fire I-Ships on world *aa* at converts
P*aa*CC	Conditionally fire P-Ships on world *aa* at converts

Probe an adajacent world

F*aa*P*bb*	Use a ship from fleet *aa* to probe world *bb*
I*aa*P*bb*	Use an I-Ship from world *aa* to probe world *bb*
P*aa*P*bb*	Use a P-Ship from world *aa* to probe world *bb*

Move a fleet one, two, or three worlds

F*aa*W*bb*	Move fleet *aa* to world *bb*
F*aa*W*bb*W*cc*	Move fleet *aa* to world *cc* (via world *bb*-world *cc*)
F*aa*W*bb*W*cc*W*dd*	Move fleet *aa* to world *dd* (via world *bb*-world *cc*-world *dd*)

Construct Starbridges

F*aa*D*bb*	Destroy the starbridge (connection) between the world occupied by fleet *aa* and the world occupied by fleet *bb*.‡
F*aa*C*bb*	Construct a new starbridge between the world occupied by fleet *aa* and the world occupied by fleet *bb*.‡
F*aa*D*bb*C*cc*	Simultaneously destroy the starbridge between the world occupied by fleet *aa* and the world occupied by fleet *bb*, and construct a new one between the world occupied by fleet *aa* and the world occupied by fleet *cc*.‡

Plunder

W*aa*X	Plunder world *aa*

Miscellaneous

TN=*name*	Name your team "Team *name*." This order is only relevant for a Team game, and only if the team has not already been named. At least one player on a team should issue this order. If multiple players on a team suggest different names, the name is selected at random. Use a + to indicate a space, and URL encoding for other special characters.

*This order is optional. Fleets that have not been given any movement or fire orders will perform ambush fire whether or not you have issued the order F*aa*S. However, issuing this order can help make it easier for you to remember that you intended a particular fleet specifically to do nothing in a particular turn, as opposed to a fleet that you may have simply overlooked.

†These orders are available only when the optional Arms Dealer character type is involved in the game; they can be used by Arms Dealer players only. They invoke the special power of using fleet ships as industry, consuming onboard metal.

‡These orders are available only when the optional Architect character type is involved in the game; they can be used by Architect players only. In all of these orders, the ships required for the operation are taken from fleet *aa*.

Turn Phases: the sequence of actions within a turn

An RSW turn is divided into eight phases. The actions in each phase happen simultaneously unless otherwise specified. In the list below, actions shown in *italics* are specific to a particular character type.

In the RSW Client, you may choose to sort your order list according to the "Phase" column by clicking on that column. This will group orders into these phases to help you easily see the sequence in which the actions of the next turn will be performed.

Phase 1 : Initial

- Auto-ambush may be turned off at some or all worlds.
- A player may be declared to be an ally. (This lasts until the player is declared not to be an ally).
- A player may be declared not to be an ally.
- A player may be declared to be a loader, thus allowing that player to load metal from your worlds. (This lasts until the player is declared not to be a loader.)
- A player may be declared not to be a loader.
- A fleet may be declared to be at peace. (This will continue until the fleet is declared not at peace.)
- A fleet may be declared to be not at peace.
- *A Missionary may pronounce Judgment against another player.*

Phase 2 : Unloading

- Metal on fleets may be unloaded to the local world.
- Metal on fleets may be converted to consumer goods and unloaded to the local world.
- Metal on fleets may be jettisoned.
- 1 industry may be created by scrapping 6 I-Ships *(4 I-Ships for the Emperor).*

Phase 3 : Transfer

- Ships may be freely exchanged between fleets, I-Ships and P-Ships.

Phase 4 : Building

- For each usable industry a ship may be built onto I-Ships, P-Ships, or any orbiting fleet.
- For each usable industry one population (including converts or robots) may be migrated to an adjacent world.
- The population limit of a world may be increased by 1 with 5 metal and 5 industry.
- A new industry may be built with 5 metal and 5 industry *(4 for Empire builder).*
- *Two robots may be built by a Positronix for each usable industry.*
- Any remaining unused usable industry will build I-Ships.

Phase 5 : Loading

- Metal on a world may be loaded onto orbiting fleets.
- Artifacts may be hooked from a world onto orbiting fleets *(or from any fleet onto a Collector's fleet).*
- Artifacts may be dropped from fleets onto the world below.

Phase 6 and 7 : Combat and Movement

These two phases interrelate. Although Combat traditionally occurs before movement, a fleet that is about to move away from a fleet firing at it will take only half damage. However, destroying a fleet

will successfully prevent it from ambush-firing any passing fleets that turn.

- A fleet may probe one or more worlds adjacent to the world it orbits at the beginning of the turn, at the cost of one ship per world probed.
- I-Ships and P-Ships may probe one or more adjacent worlds, at the cost of one ship per world probed.
- I-Ships and/or P-Ships may perform **one** of the following actions:
    - ♦ Fire at a fleet which started the turn above its world.
    - ♦ Fire at converts on its world.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at a fleet which started the turn above its world.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at converts on its world.
    - ♦ I-Ships or P-Ships which do not perform any of the other of these actions will ambush fire at passing fleets unless auto-ambush has been turned off.
- Each fleet may perform **one** of the following actions:
    - ♦ Move to a world through up to 2 intervening worlds.
    - ♦ Fire at a fleet which started the turn above the same world.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at a fleet which started the turn above the same world.
    - ♦ Fire at I-Ships and Industry.
    - ♦ Fire at P-Ships and Population.
    - ♦ Fire at I-Ships and P-Ships.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at I-Ships and Industry.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at P-Ships and Population.
    - ♦ Conditionally fire at I-Ships and P-Ships.
    - ♦ *A Positronix fleet may convert ships to robots and drop them on the local world.*
    - ♦ Drop a Planet Buster Bomb (PBB) on the local world.
    - ♦ A fleet which does not perform any of these actions will ambush fire at passing fleets unless auto-ambush has been turned off.

Phase 8 : Final

- *Commandeer: a Raider will automatically capture fleets at worlds where their ships outnumber their opponent's ships by more than 3 to 1.*
- A world may be plundered.
- A fleet with 26 or more ships may build a Planet Buster Bomb (PBB).
- Population above the population limit die.
- Up to two worlds or fleets may be given to another player or players.